

INTRO TO SOCIAL MEDIA



Cheryl Lawson
Oklahoma State University

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

Preface

Open Education at Oklahoma State University

Accessibility Statement

Reviews

Licensing

1: Marketing Principles

- 1.1: Marketing in the Age of COVID-19
- 1.2: How Many P's are in Marketing Now?
- 1.3: Applying Basic Marketing Principles to Social Media Marketing
- 1.4: What's it All For?
- 1.5: Social Media Marketing. A Brief History
- 1.6: Do You Even Google?

2: Crafting a Social Media Strategy for Your Business

- 2.1: What Business Are You Even In?
- 2.2: Case Study - Amazon in 2023 by Sunil Gupta and Margaret L. Rodriguez
- 2.3: Who Is Your Customer?
- 2.4: Customer Personas and D.I.S.C
- 2.5: Competition Check

3: Social Media 101

- 3.1: Every Network is an Island
- 3.2: Analyzing Twitter's Evolution - BM to AM
- 3.3: What Network is on Now?
- 3.4: The ROI of Your Mother (GaryVee said it, not me)
- 3.5: Content Speaks
- 3.6: Winning Combo - Content, Marketing, and Measurement - The "See, Think, Do, Care" Framework
- 3.7: Time Management
- 3.8: We're Engaged! Aren't We?
- 3.9: Social Media Jobs. Why Understanding Basic Marketing Principles Will Put You Ahead of the Rest
- 3.10: YOLO
- 3.11: 2023 Internet Minute Infographic, by eDiscovery Today and LTMG! - eDiscovery Trends
- 3.12: Facebook a Meta

4: Course Project

- 4.1: Course Project - Create a Social Media Strategy

[Bibliography](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

[Detailed Licensing](#)

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Preface

1

This book is aimed at managers, business owners, marketing managers, and aspiring social media marketing interns and managers. I will assume that however accomplished in your own field – baker, developer, teacher and that even as successful business owners, you approach the topic of social media marketing as a beginner. Even if you are a digital native, or an avid personal user of social networks, we will treat this book as a guided tour of social media for marketing purposes.

While this is a textbook, it is not meant to read like a traditional textbook, especially on a topic that is rooted in digital to an audience who, let's be honest, doesn't really like to read. No shade. I too would rather watch a YouTube video on how to fix a problem with my laptop than read the manual.

Like many of my [Generation X](#) peers, I began using forums and chat rooms in the early 1990's and have watched social networks come and go (AOL and Yahoo chat rooms, Friendster, Myspace) – To those not inclined to spend countless hours online over the past couple of decades, it may seem as if things change too often.

For others, particularly those born into the technology, aka digital natives, social networks as with most technology, are second nature to you, but not having work experience may leave you perplexed as to what your boss/ client / customers really want from you as a social media manager.

If you fall within either one of these audiences, this book is for you. I will do my best to help you sort out a basic understanding of the why of social media as a marketing tool for business, for personal brand building, and perhaps more importantly, where to find supporting information and research to help you design, monitor, test, and re-define a social media marketing strategy.

If you are utilizing this book as an instructor or are considering using this book as an instructor, first of all, *Thank you very much!* Here, you will find the instruction plan and a practical way of teaching students how the principles of marketing work. We will also explore the principles for each prominent social website. Also, the exercises with every chapter will give students a better chance at understanding these concepts as well.

To sum it up, the target audience for the book is a person who is interested in social media marketing for brand building.

PLAN OF THE BOOK

PART 1 — we'll discuss the origins of marketing principles. A definition of marketing and how many of the concepts that have been around for ages are the same as what we do today in social media marketing. Part 1 answers the question, "what is marketing?" and we'll begin to explore marketing strategies for the modern age. We'll touch on the basics principles of marketing and a bit of the psychology of as a way to introduce concepts that hopefully won't be so foreign to you as we dive deeper into the nature of social networks.

PART 2 — we'll get into more of what social media marketers know and how it fits within a marketing strategy. We'll talk about social networks in a way that no matter what networks are present and popular when you read this book, you'll have an understanding of how you can create content, engage with your customers, and grow your brand.

Open Education at Oklahoma State University

2

Introduction to Social Media is an Open Educational Resource (OER). This means the book is free (It was a good joke, right?). When Dr. Joshua Daniel became Director of First Year Composition in June of 2020, one of the first things he did was survey instructors and students to learn what they thought of the program. At that time, the program had two commercial textbooks students were required to purchase, and they were in negotiations with another textbook company to add a third. Many things became clear when he talked to students and instructors, but two points are relevant here: 1) instructors hated using the textbooks; 2) students hated the textbooks and generally did not do the reading. Dr. Daniel didn't think that is because instructors or students are lazy; he thought it was because commercial textbooks generally aren't very good. The reason for this is they, as products that need to be marketed and sold for profit, need to be as applicable as possible in as many contexts as possible. In other words, the textbooks the program was using stood the best chance of being profitable if they were equally as useful at OSU as they would be at OU, or UC Davis, or NYU. See the problem? Even though many commercial textbooks are quite good, by being applicable in so many contexts, they are never as good as they could be in any specific context. This book was built by and for the instructor of this course, an entrepreneur and practicing professional in her field. Moreover, when we find problems, we get to update it as you go (none of that, "Do I have to purchase the third edition, or can I get by with the second edition?").

So that's a reason to embrace Open Education: the textbooks are better. Here is another. Education is both a right for every human being and a responsibility for every democratic nation. Speaking as a 90's child now staggered by student loan debt, Joshua Daniel comments with certainty you are already paying more than enough for your education, and textbooks for your courses, when possible, should not add to that burden. All told, if you calculate the three textbooks previously in use for the first year composition program, students were spending just under half a million dollars per academic year on commercial textbooks. This for textbooks that instructors hated and students did not read. Not the best investment, at least not for us. Dr. Daniel believes all of you have a right to pursue education as far as you wish, and a small way we can help enable that is to remove as many barriers to entry as possible. Dr. Daniel was a first-generation college student. He grew up on a farm in Mississippi. Both of his parents had to drop out of high school for work, and none of his siblings were able to pursue higher education. When he arrived at my first undergraduate institution (he bounced around quite a few before he managed to graduate) he was lost and straight up broke. He dropped more than one course simply because he could not afford the textbooks. Many of your instructors have similar stories to this. For this reason as well as others, the instructor of this course is committed to removing the cost of commercial textbooks as a barrier to your education.

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3

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- It has been optimized for people who use screen-reader technology.
 - all content can be navigated using a keyboard.
 - links, headings, and tables are formatted to work with screen readers.
- All images in this guide are screenshots that are considered non-essential as they are described fully in the text. As such, they do not include alt tags.
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Other file formats available

In addition to the web version, this book is available in a number of file formats including print PDF, EPUB (for eReaders), digital PDF and various editable files. [Here is a link](#) to where you can download this book in another file format. Look for the Download this book drop-down menu to select the file type you want.

Known accessibility issues and areas for improvement

While we strive to ensure that this resource is as accessible and usable as possible, we might not always get it right. Any issues we identify will be listed below. There are currently no known issues.

List of Known Accessibility Issues

Location of Issue	Need for Improvement	Timeline	Work Around

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This statement was last updated on June 23, 2022, by Kathy Essmiller.

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Reviews

4

This resource can also be found in [MERLOT](#), and [OERCommons](#). It has been endorsed by Open Illinois and selected to be included in the [Open Illinois Collection](#). This resource was also selected [for review](#) by the MERLOT Business Editorial Board, who gave it an overall rating of 4.5 stars out of 5.

“As a business instructor, this is one of the best social media books I have seen to date.”

“Overall strong resource for marketers and/or social media folks.”

“Easy to include in the right course/topic.”

“The material is written in such a way that it does not read like a textbook. The material is relevant as it discusses marketing after COVID. The content is interesting and easy to read. [This] could be used as part of a marketing course or a social media course.” Content Quality, MERLOT Business Editorial Board

“The book can be used as the primary course resource or as a supplement to a broader topic course. The book and topics promote conceptual understanding by starting with the concepts of marketing and moving into this particular type of marketing. The book could be used as supplemental reading or as the primary source. The book includes concept information as well as additional readings and activities.” Potential Effectiveness as a Teaching Tool, MERLOT Business Editorial Board

“The material is clearly defined for use and student. Site was in working order [and] is easy to navigate. Activities were included in appropriate sections and were relevant and easy to use. Generally meets accessibility requirements.” Ease of Use for Students and Faculty, MERLOT Business Editorial Board

Licensing

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Marketing Principles

- 1.1: Marketing in the Age of COVID-19
- 1.2: How Many P's are in Marketing Now?
- 1.3: Applying Basic Marketing Principles to Social Media Marketing
- 1.4: What's it All For?
- 1.5: Social Media Marketing. A Brief History
- 1.6: Do You Even Google?

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1.1: Marketing in the Age of COVID-19

So, remember when COVID-19 hit and the world turned upside down? Yeah, me too. We had to change the way we lived and worked in the blink of an eye. And boy, did we realize how vital social media and digital platforms were for our professional and personal lives. Just think about companies like Zoom, Instacart, TikTok, and YouTube – they were the real MVPs during the pandemic. Let's dive into how the global crisis shook up marketing and made social media the star of the show.

1.1 Embracing the Digital Life (and Hoarding Toilet Paper)

When the pandemic struck, we quickly learned that working from home was the new norm. We didn't need to be at the office to get stuff done – all we needed was a laptop and a decent internet connection (and maybe some pants, but who's checking?).

Oh, and speaking of the pandemic, can we talk about how we all suddenly became obsessed with toilet paper? It turns out, people were using 40% more of it while stuck at home ([source](#)). That's a lot of TP, folks. But let's get back to the topic at hand...

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Illustration 201534357 / Business © Regina Tolgyesi | Dreamstime.com

1.2 Social Media: Our Lifeline in Lockdown

As we hunkered down in our homes, social media became more crucial than ever. It was our connection to the outside world, our source of news, and a way to keep in touch with friends and family. Businesses caught on, and those who hadn't already embraced social media marketing were suddenly scrambling to get on board.

Let me give you a personal example. I've been producing an annual social media conference since 2011, and we were all set to celebrate our 10th anniversary in March 2020. Talk about bad timing, right? With just a few weeks to spare, I had to make the tough call to postpone the conference until September (because, you know, maybe the pandemic would be over by then... oh, how naive we were).

But here's the silver lining: between March and September, the mobile app we'd been using as a bonus feature for our conference – Whova – became our saving grace. It created a community for event organizers like myself, where we could swap best practices for transitioning our events from in-person to virtual. And you know what? Even though we couldn't all meet up in Tulsa like we'd planned, our virtual conference went off without a hitch, thanks to Zoom, Vimeo, and Whova.

So there you have it – a firsthand example of how social media and digital platforms swooped in to save the day during the chaos of COVID-19. And if that's not a testament to their power, I don't know what is.

1.3 What Is Marketing?

Alright, let's get down to the nitty-gritty: what the heck is marketing, anyway? I know what you're thinking – isn't it just selling and advertising? Well, hold on to your hats, because there's a lot more to it than that.

The [American Marketing Association](#) gives us this definition:

“The activity, set of institutions, and processes for creating, communicating, delivering, and exchanging offerings that have value for customers, clients, partners, and society at large.”

In plain English, marketing pros help businesses win over new customers by offering them something they can't resist – and then keeping them happy so they'll stick around and spread the word. It's all about creating a value proposition that's simply too good to pass up.

1.4 What is Marketing Today? With Seth Godin

In Seth Godin's video “What is Marketing Today?”, he emphasizes that marketing has shifted from being a side effect to the core of what businesses do. In the past, companies would simply produce average products and rely on marketing teams to sell them. However, today's marketing landscape is centered around telling a story, connecting with customers, and focusing on how products can make a difference in people's lives.

Godin argues that old-school marketing, which involved buying mass media ads to reach average consumers, is fading away. The internet has turned into a medium of micro-segments, where companies can no longer buy attention in the same way they did with TV advertising. Instead, businesses need to pick their niche, measure when necessary, and focus on building connections, trust, and attention.

Godin emphasizes the importance of understanding your “why” but also recognizing that it’s often a general concept. The key is to identify who you seek to serve and make things better for them. By continuously improving, earning trust, and transforming attention into a promise and a brand, you can achieve success regardless of your profession.

Lastly, Godin stresses the responsibility that comes with marketing, as every action has an effect. Marketers must own the consequences of their campaigns and strive to create products and messages they’re proud of. By focusing on making things better and inventing products that positively impact the world, marketers can contribute to meaningful change.

Exercise: Watch the video in class



1.5 What Is Digital Marketing?

At a high level, digital marketing refers to advertising delivered through digital channels such as search engines, websites, social media, email, and mobile apps. Using these online media channels, digital marketing is the method by which companies endorse goods, services, and brands. Consumers heavily rely on digital means to research products. For example, Think with Google marketing insights found that 48% of consumers start their inquiries on search engines, whereas 33% prefer to consult brand websites and the remaining 26% consumers search within mobile applications.

While modern day digital marketing is an enormous system of channels to which marketers simply must onboard their brands, advertising online is much more complex than the channels alone. In order to achieve the true potential of digital marketing, marketers have to dig deep into today’s vast and intricate cross-channel world to discover strategies that make an impact through engagement marketing. Engagement marketing is the method of forming meaningful interactions with potential and returning customers based on the data you collect over time. By engaging customers in a digital landscape, you build brand awareness, set yourself as an industry thought leader, and place your business at the forefront when the customer is ready to buy.

By implementing an omnichannel digital marketing strategy, marketers can collect valuable insights into target audience behaviors while opening the door to new methods of customer engagement. Additionally, companies can expect to see an increase in retention. According to a report by Invesp, companies with strong omnichannel customer engagement strategies can retain around 89% of their customers as compared to companies with weaker omnichannel programs that have a retention rate of just 33%.

As for the future of digital marketing, we can expect to see a continued increase in the variety of wearable devices available to consumers. Forbes also forecasts that social media will become increasingly conversational in the B2B space, video content will be refined for search engine optimization (SEO) purposes, and email marketing will become even more personalized.

“Digital is at the core of everything in marketing today—it has gone from ‘one of the things marketing does’ to ‘THE thing that marketing does.’”

– Sanjay Dholakia, Former Chief Marketing Officer, Marketo

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1.2: How Many P's are in Marketing Now?

While we're learning Marketing concepts, let's talk about the Marketing Mix. Even though the marketing world has gone digital, this "old-school" concept is very relevant today. We're talking about the 4 P's of Marketing. First, who do we have to thank for this? Neil Borden first came up with the term Marketing Mix, but it was Jerome McCarthy from Notre Dame University who really made it famous. He called it "the Four P's of Marketing" in his guide, "Basic Marketing: A Managerial Approach".

The legendary marketing guru, Philip Kotler, said it best: "Marketing Mix is the set of controllable variables that a firm can use to influence the buyer's response." What's cool about this is that digital and social media marketing still use these age-old concepts. We're just adapting them to new tools and methods, making them work in the digital world. So, the 4 P's are still alive and kicking, even in the age of Instagram and TikTok!



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Let's dive into the 4 P's of marketing, keeping it short and sweet

Product: This is the good or service you're offering to your customers. It includes everything from the design, features, packaging, and even the product life cycle. The goal is to create something that solves a problem or fulfills a need.

Price: This is how much you charge for your product. It's about finding the sweet spot between making a profit and offering value to your customers. Factors like production costs, competition, and perceived value all come into play when setting the right price.

Place: This is where and how you distribute your product to reach your target audience. It includes choosing the right channels, such as online stores, brick-and-mortar shops, or both. The goal is to make your product accessible and convenient for your customers to buy.

Promotion: This is how you communicate your product's value to your target audience. It involves a mix of marketing strategies like advertising, public relations, social media, and content marketing. The goal is to create awareness, generate interest, and ultimately, persuade people to buy your product.

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1.3: Applying Basic Marketing Principles to Social Media Marketing

Some people are confused about social media, but it's essential to understand that social marketing has been around for a long time. Digital and social media marketing are not new philosophies; they are traditional practices adapted to new tools.

Historically, business was conducted in social settings like door-to-door sales or marketplaces. These gatherings allowed people to share ideas and communicate across networks. Similarly, event marketing created connections between buyers and sellers through dealer conferences or even extravagant parties attended by influential individuals.

Nowadays, many of these connections happen online through platforms like LinkedIn or Facebook. However, some businesspeople shy away from using these modern technologies as they appear daunting compared to traditional methods such as television, radio, newspaper advertising or direct mail campaigns.

The ease of digital marketing allows businesses to quickly share their stories by taking pictures or conducting interviews with just a smartphone. Despite the low cost of entry into this form of promotion, many entrepreneurs still find it challenging due to lack of education in marketing principles and strategy creation.

Social media is simply another way to market a product or service using traditional theories adapted for new mediums. Each platform has its own language and style which requires tailored communication strategies for success.

The main difference between traditional and modern-day digital/social media marketing lies in the technology available today rather than any significant change in underlying principles.

Before we move forward, let's go back to some of our earlier definitions of marketing by Seth Godin;

"Marketing is at the core of what we do. It is the story you tell, who you're telling it to, and why people are going to buy your product or service."

He also said, ***"Marketing is no longer about the stuff that you make, but about the stories you tell"***.

The 4Ps Reimagined: Translating Marketing Mix to Social Media

While social media marketing is relatively recent in the grand scheme of things, marketing itself isn't new at all. Applying foundational marketing concepts to social media is not just essential, but also incredibly effective. By grounding your social media strategy in these tried-and-true marketing principles, you'll be better equipped to leverage these platforms and communicate your brand message powerfully and persuasively.

Product is where we begin. (When I use 'product' here, I mean product or service) It's critical to understand what sets your product apart and how it enriches your customer's life. These unique insights allow you to effectively utilize platforms like LinkedIn, Instagram, or YouTube to tell your product story. Keep in mind that savvy customers today are not just buying a product; they're investing in your brand's narrative, which can include your connection to community, your social and environmental responsibility, and or your family connection to the product.

Then, let's discuss **Price**. This isn't just about the dollar value; it's about the perceived value your product delivers. Striking the right balance in pricing is paramount. You don't want to scare off customers by being too expensive, nor do you want to sell yourself short. E-commerce and social media have changed the pricing landscape, allowing you to operate with leaner margins and potentially pass the savings onto your customers. Techniques such as Dropshipping and Just-In-Time manufacturing can be powerful tools in your arsenal to manage costs.

Now, we move on to **Place**. This term encapsulates all the platforms where customers can find or access your offerings. Social media has revolutionized this aspect, making it possible for customers to shop from their living room while allowing you to engage, respond, and improve the customer experience in real-time.

Last, but definitely not least, **Promotion**. Traditional marketing techniques still have their place, but the digital landscape, especially social media, has opened up new possibilities. You can foster lasting relationships with your customers, earn their trust, and transform them into advocates for your brand. Promoting your brand on social media, optimizing your website for search engines, and leveraging email marketing can be cost-effective ways to enhance your visibility and reach.

As you craft your social media strategy, keep these principles at the forefront. Each one provides a lens to view your product, your customers, and the market. They aren't mere steps, but ongoing considerations that can help your brand connect, engage, and grow in the dynamic world of social media.

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1.4: What's it All For?

In the complex world of marketing, social media has emerged as a powerful tool, greatly influencing tactics and strategies. Businesses are constantly urged to invest in social media marketing, leaving many to question why it garners such emphasis amidst a plethora of alternatives. Unveiling the benefits of social media for businesses, we shall explore the tangible returns one can expect from a robust social media strategy.

Social media allows you to convey the narrative behind your product, appealing to your audience's emotions and values, thereby spreading your brand message. Crafting compelling visuals or stories around the genesis of your business, your team, or products can foster a strong brand reputation.

A significant advantage of social media marketing lies in its cost-effectiveness compared to traditional marketing approaches. It provides a level playing field for small and medium-sized businesses to compete with established brands without exorbitant expenses, thereby offering excellent return on investment.

Engaging your followers with captivating content not only retains them as loyal customers but can also turn them into brand ambassadors, extending your reach to their network. This organic promotion can reap rich dividends for your brand.

Social media's targeted advertising capability ensures that your investment is put to optimal use by reaching your desired audience. Moreover, retargeting options help keep your brand at the forefront of potential customers' minds, gently nudging them towards conversion. As we delve deeper into the purpose and significance of an impactful social media presence for businesses, it's important to highlight six key benefits that underscore why so many businesses prioritize this form of digital marketing.

These advantages are integral to a thriving online presence, influencing various aspects of a business's growth and success. They include SEO and Search Engine Optimization, Increasing Website Traffic, Decreasing Customer Acquisition Cost, Direct-to-Consumer engagement, PR and Brand Awareness, and Lead Generation. Each of these elements plays a crucial role in leveraging the power of social media to advance your brand and drive results.

SEO (Search Engine Optimization)

Search Engine Optimization (SEO) is a powerful digital marketing tool that focuses on increasing your brand's visibility on search engines. With the right SEO strategies in place, your social media platforms and website can rank higher in search engine results. This is crucial as studies show that the top results on search engine pages get the majority of clicks. By optimizing your social media profiles and creating SEO-friendly content, you can enhance your brand's online presence and reach.

Increase Website Traffic

Social media marketing can significantly drive traffic to your website. By sharing engaging content, promotional offers, blogs, product launches, and more on your social media platforms, you can entice your followers to click through to your website. This increased traffic not only brings in potential customers but also contributes to improving your site's SEO rankings. Over time, a robust social media strategy can help create a cycle of higher search rankings and increased website traffic.

Decrease Customer Acquisition Cost

Social media is a cost-effective platform for reaching potential customers and nurturing relationships with existing ones. The cost of acquiring customers through social media is often lower than traditional marketing channels due to its organic reach and precise targeting. Moreover, through retargeting capabilities, you can re-engage users who have shown interest in your brand or product, further reducing the cost of customer acquisition.

Direct to Consumer (Avoid Traditional Wholesale and Third-Party Sellers)

In traditional business models, products often go through several intermediaries such as wholesalers and retailers before reaching the end consumer. This can inflate the final price of the product and dilute the brand's control over the customer experience.

By using social media as a direct-to-consumer channel, you can sidestep these intermediaries, lowering costs and retaining more control over the customer journey. This model allows you to understand your customers' preferences, needs, and behaviors in real-time, enabling you to tailor your products and services accordingly. In addition, direct interaction with consumers can foster a stronger sense of community and loyalty around your brand.

PR Brand Awareness

Public Relations (PR) and brand awareness go hand in hand. Social media provides a platform where businesses can not only promote their products or services but also shape public perception by sharing their company's mission, values, and stories. It is an opportunity to humanize your brand and build a reputation that resonates with your audience.

Social media platforms are ideal for conducting PR campaigns. They allow you to reach a wider audience and give you the opportunity to engage directly with them. This could involve answering customer queries, addressing concerns, or simply thanking them for their support. Such interaction fosters a positive image of your brand and enhances your reputation.



Moreover, social media enables real-time communication during crisis situations, allowing you to manage your reputation effectively. By proactively responding to issues and demonstrating your commitment to customer satisfaction, you can maintain and even improve your brand image.

Lead generation is another key benefit of social media marketing. Social media platforms offer various tools and features that can assist in collecting potential leads. This includes call-to-action buttons, direct messaging, and ad campaigns specifically designed to capture user information.

By sharing engaging content and building relationships with your audience on social media, you can attract potential customers who may be interested in your products or services. Once these potential leads are identified, they can be nurtured through targeted content and personalized engagement, ultimately guiding them through the sales funnel.

Moreover, social media platforms offer advanced targeting options, allowing you to reach out to the right audience who are more likely to become quality leads. In this way, social media can efficiently and effectively enhance your lead generation efforts.

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1.5: Social Media Marketing. A Brief History

Social media is a broad term that encompasses a wide range of online platforms and tools that allow users to connect and share content with each other. The history of social media is long and complex, but it can be traced back to the early days of the internet.

One of the earliest examples of social media was Usenet, which was created in 1982. Usenet was a system of discussion forums where users could post messages and reply to each other. Another early example of social media was Six Degrees, which was launched in 1997. Six Degrees was a social networking site that allowed users to connect with friends and family members.

In the early 2000s, social media began to take off. In 2004, Facebook was launched, and it quickly became one of the most popular social media platforms in the world. In 2005, YouTube was launched, and it revolutionized the way people watch and share videos. In 2006, Twitter was launched, and it became the go-to platform for sharing short updates and news.

In the years since, social media has continued to evolve. New platforms have been launched, and existing platforms have been updated with new features. Social media has also become increasingly important in our lives. We use it to stay connected with friends and family, to learn about current events, and to share our thoughts and ideas with the world.

Social media has had a profound impact on our society. It has changed the way we communicate, the way we consume news, and the way we interact with the world around us. It is still too early to say what the future holds for social media, but it is clear that it will continue to play an important role in our lives and our businesses.

 The history of social media networks in america. infographic

Storytime

Let me tell you about December 2005. I saw a Business Week cover headline, “The Myspace Generation,” and it just clicked. I was only a year into starting my own event planning biz, and my new client was a dance conference who’s audience was 18-25-year-old women. Myspace was their jam – seriously, it was the new mall hangout.

So, what did I do? I hopped on the Myspace train and used it for the dance conference to dish out resources like tryout dates, dance makeup, and clothing recommendations. We became the ultimate one-stop-shop for all things dance and our efforts resulted in the conference being in the black for the first time.

A bunch of us Gen Xers credit Myspace for teaching us HTML back in the day. It’s crazy to think about it now with TikTok ruling the roost, but Myspace was our first taste of being social online.

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1.6: Do You Even Google?

Get ready for this chapter, “Do You Even Google?”, where we dive into the significance of search engine optimization (SEO) and how it impacts everything we do online. Our main goal? Make sure our social media posts and website content are super easy to find.

Let’s not forget platforms like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube, which have their own search engines for users to discover content. Fun fact: YouTube is the world’s second-largest search engine, giving birth to the term “YouTube University.”

Oh, and can we talk about “near me” searches on mobile devices? It’s a game-changer when people are hunting for products or services.

Big brain business name 🧠 pic.twitter.com/iY1lhi4gAJ

— Alicia Tatone (@AliciaTatone) [March 28, 2023](#)

As savvy business owners and marketers, we need to know how folks find us online. Sure, ROI and engagement metrics matter, but creating searchable content should be top of mind.

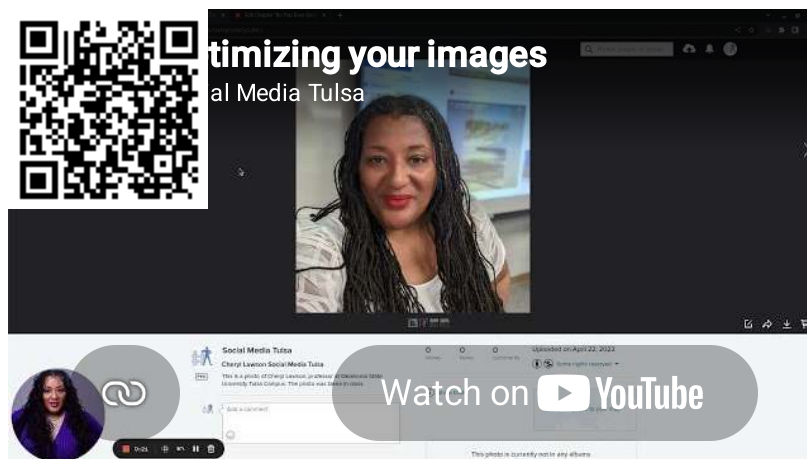
That means getting found on big-time search engines like Google and Bing, as well as individual social networks. And hey, let’s not forget about Google Business profiles. Though not technically social media, they can be part of our social media strategies. Pop those eye-catching social campaign creatives on your Google Business pages too! **Bottom line:** Optimize everything from image titles to alt text descriptions, so search engines can’t resist indexing your content.

? In Class Exercise: Google yourself!

Google your name and take note of the results that show up. This activity can help you understand the importance of your online presence and how search engines present information about you. It can also encourage discussions about personal branding, digital footprints, and strategies to improve visibility in search results.

Creating SEO with Your Photos Using Flickr

Taking advantage of every SEO opportunity is crucial for your online visibility, and this includes optimizing your images. Using platforms like Flickr to host your photos allows you to enhance your photo SEO, as it provides fields for adding titles and descriptions to individual and bulk images. These additional details not only make your photos more accessible to people browsing the web but also to search engine algorithms. When uploading photos to your website, take the time to rename them using relevant keywords and phrases. This simple step ensures your images contribute positively to your website’s SEO. Remember, every bit of “search engine juice” matters, and properly optimizing your photos can give you an edge in the increasingly visual digital landscape.



Wrapping up this section, let's discuss an invaluable tool that can help you stay informed and monitor your brand or personal brand online: Google Alerts.

Google Alerts is a free service provided by Google that allows you to set up alerts for specific keywords or phrases. When new content containing those keywords or phrases is published on the web, you'll receive an email notification. This tool is especially useful for discovering content to share on social media platforms, as well as keeping track of mentions about your brand or personal brand.

By setting up Google Alerts for your business name, industry keywords, or even your own name, you can keep a pulse on what's being said about you, your business, or your industry. This information can not only help you curate content to share with your audience, but it can also provide valuable insights into public perception and enable you to address any potential issues or concerns.

 "Google alerts.jpg" by Wikimedia Commons is licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0

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Furthermore, Google Alerts can be a helpful tool for competitor analysis. By monitoring your competitors' online presence and content, you can gain insights into their marketing strategies, identify gaps or opportunities, and stay ahead of the game.

In summary, utilizing Google Alerts can be an essential part of your overall digital marketing and social media strategy. It allows you to stay informed, monitor your brand, find shareable content, and keep an eye on the competition. With just a few simple steps, you can set up alerts tailored to your needs and ensure you never miss out on vital information in the digital world.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Crafting a Social Media Strategy for Your Business

2.1: What Business Are You Even In?

2.2: Case Study - Amazon in 2023 by Sunil Gupta and Margaret L. Rodriguez

2.3: Who Is Your Customer?

2.4: Customer Personas and D.I.S.C

2.5: Competition Check

Thumbnail: Facebook page of an entrepreneur's social media on desktop and mobile. (Unsplash License; [Austin Distel](#) via [Unsplash](#))

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2.1: What Business Are You Even In?

In this section, we'll dive into the art of crafting a rock-solid social media strategy that's custom-made for your business. But first things first: let's nail down what type of business you're running. Are you in the apparel game, living that lifestyle brand life, flexing your creative muscles, schooling folks in education, or hustling in the service or B2B/B2C support industry? Pinpointing your business type is crucial, but remember, you're not boxed in – think of how Amazon evolved from a mere online bookstore to an everything store.

Now, before we go all-in on marketing strategies (be it traditional or social media), we need to make sure we can explain our business in a way that's snappy and easy to grasp. No, you don't have to cram it all into a 30-second elevator pitch, but you should be able to convey your message clearly and efficiently across different organizations and industries. Your message should scream, "This is who we are, and this is why we do what we do!" Easy peasy.

So, what's next? Let's dig deeper into the components of a killer social media strategy. We'll talk about how to align your social media goals with your overall business objectives, define your target audience, and create content that speaks their language. We'll also explore the importance of analyzing your competition and staying on top of trends that are relevant to your industry.

And, of course, we'll dive into the nitty-gritty of choosing the right social media platforms and tools that suit your unique business needs. With the right blend of creativity, analytics, and good ol' fashioned hustle, you'll be well on your way to crafting a social media strategy that gets your message out there, engages your audience, and drives results for your business.

It's time to make your social media game unstoppable with a strategy that's tailored to your one-of-a-kind business. Let's do this!

Additional Reading

[Understanding the Business You Are In | by B. L. Teague | The Startup | Medium](#)

[New insights for new growth: What it takes to understand your customers today \(mckinsey.com\)](#)

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2.2: Case Study - Amazon in 2023 by Sunil Gupta and Margaret L. Rodriguez

I like to bring in the Harvard Business Publishing case [“Amazon in 2023” by Sunil Gupta and Margaret Rodriguez](#) to give students a solid, real-world example.

Abstract: Amazon kicked off its journey in July 1995, selling books online. Fast forward to 2020, and it's a digital behemoth raking in over \$280 billion in yearly sales. A significant chunk of its growth comes from branching out into various businesses that some might consider unrelated. So, is Amazon spreading itself too thin, or is it strategically positioning itself for future success?

Now, your students might not have access to the actual case, but let me break down some core concepts from the authors, so everyone can grasp the essentials without the case. Plus, this'll help anyone teaching with the textbook to integrate the case more effectively.

In today's market landscape, broad differentiation – being cheaper or better – is no longer enough to succeed. The digital era requires businesses to connect consumers and products through network effects and complementary offerings. This “winner-take-all” strategy creates connections between different industries, as seen with Amazon Studios videos offered for free with Prime memberships, leading to increased spending on their e-commerce platform.

Sunil Gupta, a professor at Harvard Business School, has spent over 12 years researching how technologies are changing consumer behavior and business strategies. His case study “Amazon in 2023” examines Amazon's expansion into seemingly unrelated businesses and raises questions about whether this lack of focus is detrimental or if it's positioning the company for future success.

Gupta emphasizes that differentiation alone is not enough in the digital era. Instead, businesses need to connect consumers and products through network effects and complementary offerings. This approach allows companies to be a “razor” in one industry and a “blade” in another, such as Amazon offering free videos through Prime to increase spending on their e-commerce platform.

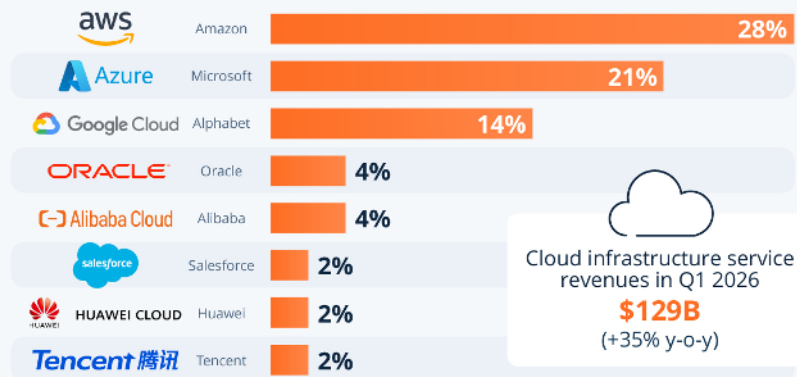
When teaching this case, Gupta encourages pushing students to think more deeply about Amazon's various ventures and question who the company is competing with. This case study can be easily taught online and appeals to a wide range of student groups. The key is to enjoy the case, stay updated on the latest developments, and engage in meaningful discussions about Amazon's evolving strategies.



In this 2010 interview with Charlie Rose, Jeff Bezos, the founder and former CEO of Amazon, shares his insights on Amazon's competitive advantage, how they approach competition. Bezos explains that Amazon's approach to maintaining a competitive edge consists of three key factors: a wide selection, low prices, and fast, convenient, reliable delivery. He also emphasizes the importance of being customer-obsessed, focusing on the customer more than on competitors. Bezos highlights that Amazon's online business model allows for cost structure advantages and that their purchasing power is now comparable to that of Walmart. Additionally, Bezos it's almost scary how much foresight Bezos had regarding Amazon Web Services.

Big Three Hold Dominant Lead in Accelerating Cloud Market

Worldwide market share of leading cloud infrastructure service providers in Q1 2026*



* Includes platform as a service (PaaS) and infrastructure as a service (IaaS) as well as hosted private cloud services
Source: Synergy Research Group



statista

You will find more infographics at [Statista](https://www.statista.com/)

Questions for discussion or quiz

- What business is Amazon in? Are they spreading themselves too thin or are they well-positioned for the future?
- Who are Amazon's competitors? And what is Amazon's competitive advantage?
- What should traditional retailers like Best Buy do to compete with Amazon?

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2.3: Who Is Your Customer?

Creating Buyer Persona

 English: User personas from the Wikimedia Foundation's New Readers project.

Let's talk about creating customer personas! A customer persona is like a character sketch of your perfect customer. You base it on actual data from your current customers and research into your target market. Knowing your customers' needs, wants, and pain points helps you tailor marketing and sales strategies that really click with them.

So, how do you create a customer persona? First, gather data about your target market. You can get this from:

- Customer surveys
- Website analytics
- Social media insights
- Industry reports

Now, with your data in hand, let's build that persona. Give them a name and a job title. Then, dive into the details:

- Demographics: Age, gender, location, income level, and so on.
- Psychographics: Interests, hobbies, values, and more.
- Challenges: What big hurdles does your persona face?
- Goals: What's your persona aiming for?
- Pain points: What bothers or frustrates your persona?
- Needs: What does your persona need to reach their goals?

With your customer persona complete, use it to shape your marketing and sales strategies. For instance, craft targeted content that speaks to their interests, or develop sales pitches that address their specific needs and pain points.

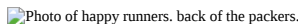
Creating customer personas is super helpful for boosting your marketing and sales results. By really understanding your target market, you can design campaigns that convert leads into customers more effectively.

A few extra tips for creating customer personas:

- Get different perspectives by involving multiple people in the process.
- Be as specific as possible—the more details, the better.
- Keep your personas up-to-date as your target market evolves.

Storytime

Here's a personal example of how creating customer personas can be a valuable exercise. When I was working as the marketing director for the Route 66 Marathon in Tulsa, we started working on our customer personas. The good news was that through the registration process, we already had a lot of information about each of our participants. A lot of that information even showed up on their runner bib, such as which distance they were running or walking. If they were a member of a running club, which start corral they were in. Being in corral A or B meant they were more likely a fast runner, while C or D indicated they were either one of our "party runners," back-of-the-packers, or they simply registered late.



During the registration process, we also asked if they would like to participate in our bloggers/social media panel and inquired about their job. So, by looking at photos on a plane ride back from a conference, we were able to identify and create our personas. By understanding the different types of participants, we could then create targeted marketing campaigns that catered to the various runner profiles, enhancing our overall marketing strategy.

In summary, gathering as much information as possible about your customers from the very beginning is crucial to creating effective customer personas. The more data you have about their demographics, psychographics, challenges, goals, pain points, and needs, the better you can tailor your marketing and sales strategies to resonate with them. By understanding your customers' unique characteristics, you can create targeted campaigns that drive engagement and conversions, ultimately leading to a more successful business.

How to Create a Buyer Persona



Free Buyer Person Template by SEMrush: <http://smr.sh/Kdc>

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2.4: Customer Personas and D.I.S.C

I have been using the DISC (D-I-S-C) method for many years in various classes, ranging from event planning to social media marketing. This technique is not only helpful for understanding how to communicate with customers, coworkers, colleagues, or family members but also enables us to know ourselves better.

Early in my career at General Motors, we participated in a Myers-Briggs personality style assessment. It was an eye-opening experience as I began to understand my communication preferences and recognize that others may have different styles. People want to be treated according to their preferences.

At Fleetwood RV, we incorporated DISC training into our sales system. Understanding your own communication style and identifying the customer's profile (whether they are D, I, S or C) greatly aids the sales process and helps tailor presentations accordingly.

This same concept applies in marketing when identifying customer personas. Recognizing that our preferred communication style may differ from our target audience allows us to adapt our marketing visuals, tone of voice and overall presentation on platforms such as websites or social media pages like Instagram and Facebook.

Utilizing the DISC method can significantly improve your understanding of yourself and others while enhancing your professional skills in areas like sales and marketing. There are numerous places where you can take this test – even simple versions can be found online for use during class or while reading at home.

THE SURVEY

INSTRUCTIONS FOR RESPONDING:

In the space provided below, you'll find different behaviors relating to a specific situation. Your task is to rank these behaviors based on how well they represent you, from most to least characteristic. Start from the left and assign "4" points to the behavior that best describes you in that situation. Then, assign "3" points to the next most characteristic behavior, followed by "2" points for the next one, and finally, "1" point for the behavior that least resembles you. Download the [survey](#).

EXAMPLE

3 Directing 4 Influencing 2 Steady 1 Cautious

	Dan		Iris		Shelia		Curtis
	Self-Certain		Optimistic		Deliberate		Restrained
	Adventurous		Enthusiastic		Predictable		Logical
	Decisive		Open		Patient		Analytical
	Fearless		Impulsive		Stabilizing		Precise
	Restless		Emotional		Protective		Doubting
	Competitive		Persuading		Accommodating		Curious
	Assertive		Talkative		Modest		Tactful
	Experimenting		Charming		Easy-Going		Consistent
	Forceful		Sensitive		Sincere		Perfectionists
	TOTAL		TOTAL		TOTAL		TOTAL

INSTRUCTIONS FOR COUNTING AND GRAPHING:

First, sum up the numbers in each of the four columns. Write the total number for each column in the empty space labeled "TOTAL" at the bottom of the column. To ensure accuracy, add all the columns together. The sum of all four columns should equal 100.

Next, plot the numbers from the totals columns on the graph provided below. For instance, if the total number in the “D” column was 15, you would place the plotting point (dot) halfway between the 14 and the 16 on the graph for that dimension.

D	I	S	C
40	40	40	40
38	38	38	38
36	36	36	36
34	34	34	34
32	32	32	32
30	30	30	30
28	28	28	28
26	26	26	26
24	24	24	24
22	22	22	22
20	20	20	20
18	18	18	18
16	16	16	16
14	14	14	14
12	12	12	12
10	10	10	10

After completing your graph, circle the highest visual point. This represents your strongest behavioral characteristic. The higher you score on the graph, the more intensity you bring to this particular behavioral characteristic. Look at the letter at the graph on page one which corresponds to the highest visual point. Using this letter look up your behavioral style

(D=Dan, I=Iris, S=Sheila, C=Curtis) Watch the video below for explanations or click here.



D=Dominance, I=Influencing, S=Steady, C=Cautious

Okay, now that you’ve got a handle on DISC styles, it’s time to think about how you can apply this to your customers and enhance your marketing strategy. Using DISC styles can help you pinpoint the right social media platforms to reach your customers, and tailor your content, tone, and style to match their preferences. Let’s explore this:

If your customers fall into the ‘**S**’ or **Steady Sheila** category, they might appreciate the familiar communities on Facebook or the professional connections on LinkedIn. They value consistency, patience, and long-term relationships. So, platforms that facilitate regular, meaningful engagement could be their digital hangout spots.

Those in the ‘**C**’ or **Compliant Curtis** group are all about details and clarity. They might be drawn to the defined guidelines and clear communication of LinkedIn or the fast-paced, information-dense environment of Twitter. These platforms could be their go-to sources for in-depth information and precise updates. You might also find Cs in the [Dataisbeautiful subReddit](#).

For our **‘D’ or Dominant Dan** category customers, quick, result-oriented platforms like Instagram or TikTok could be their arena. They’re dynamic, decisive, and enjoy seeing the impact of their actions. These platforms can offer them immediate engagement, inspiration, and opportunities to take action.

And for the **‘I’ or Influencing Iris** types, the networking-friendly environments of Instagram or Twitter could be their stomping grounds. They’re all about expressing their thoughts and making connections. These platforms allow them to network widely and share their influential ideas.

Remember, these are general tendencies and real-world preferences can vary. People might engage with multiple platforms for different reasons. So, it’s crucial for you as a marketer to keep your approach flexible and adaptable. Monitor your engagement, adjust your strategy, and most importantly, keep learning about your customers!

Incorporating DISC into your customer personas can give you valuable insight into how your customers think, behave, and communicate. With this in your tool kit, you can create targeted, relevant content and connect with your customers in a way that resonates with them. It’s all about meeting them where they are and speaking their language.

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2.5: Competition Check

“If you make the opportunity, you’ll be the first in the position to take advantage of it.”

– Biz Stone Co-Founder of Twitter

Let’s dive into the realm of social media competitive analysis. As a business, you’ve got competition, those pesky folks selling similar products or services as you, targeting the same crowd. With e-commerce, these competitors aren’t just on the next block, they could be across the globe.

The web has removed geographical barriers, exposing your business to a worldwide wrestling ring. Your competition isn’t just the store down the street; it’s also that trendy online shop based halfway around the globe. And believe me, their Instagram ads can be pretty slick.

Ignoring what your competitors are doing on social media? Not an option. It’s about learning their tactics, their successes, their failures. It’s about staying one step ahead. But this isn’t about being creepy, spying, or doing anything sketchy. It’s just good business sense.

Your competition could be publicly listed companies whose financial reports are easily accessible. You get a peek at their financial health, and you know what you’re up against. It’s not always a David vs Goliath scenario; often, the smaller, more innovative companies outperform their larger competitors.

When we chat about competition, it’s not always a bad thing. It keeps you on your toes, pushing you to improve your product, your customer service. Plus, you get to learn from those who’ve been around the block.

So, who are these competitors? Here’s the breakdown:

- **Direct Competition:** These are your most obvious competitors. If you’re selling pizzas, it’s the other pizza joints. Picture the Pepsi-Coca-Cola rivalry.
- **Indirect Competition:** These are a bit sneakier. If you have a toy shop downtown, your indirect competition might be that online toy store who’s also targeting your city’s kiddos.
- **Replacement Competition:** This one’s tricky. It’s about the alternatives, the substitutes. The folks who sell something different, but it can still replace what you’re offering. Like Kindle becoming the replacement for traditional books.

Coke vs. Pepsi The Ultimate Rivalry

The soft drink industry has been dominated by two cola giants for decades – Coca-Cola and Pepsi. Their fierce rivalry has fueled some of the most memorable marketing campaigns, and among them, none is more iconic than the “Pepsi Challenge.” This bold initiative, launched by Pepsi in the mid-1970s, invited consumers to participate in a blind taste test to determine which cola they preferred. The results became a pivotal moment in advertising history and sparked an ongoing debate about brand loyalty and consumer behavior. In the video, “Marketing Experts Break Down the Coke vs. Pepsi Rivalry” by Vanity Fair, experts delve into the dynamics of this legendary rivalry, revealing key insights and strategies that continue to shape the world of marketing today. Buckle up, as we take you through a rollercoaster ride of one of the most heated battles in the business landscape.



Why Perform Competitor Analysis

Why should you bother to perform a social media competitor analysis for your strategy?

First and foremost, understanding your competition gives you an understanding of your customers. It's easy for businesses to get tunnel vision, focusing on their strengths while forgetting to take a look around at what's happening in the marketplace. Competitive analysis, especially on social media, gives you a fresh set of eyes and a clearer perspective on what your customers want and need.

Secondly, it helps you identify potential threats. Keeping tabs on your competitors' social media activities gives you a heads-up on potential threats lurking around the corner. Whether it's a new market entrant or a disruptive technology, a thorough analysis of your competitors' social media activities will alert you well in advance.

Thirdly, it allows you to set relevant benchmarks. Businesses often set performance standards or Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), but without a solid understanding of the competitive landscape, these benchmarks may be out of step with the market realities. Monitoring your competitors on social media helps ensure your benchmarks are in line with industry standards.

Moreover, a social media competitor analysis is a fantastic tool for recognizing market gaps. Even in a crowded market, there's always a blind spot your competition is missing. Through a careful study of your competitors' social media activities, you could discover an untapped niche or a customer group that's been overlooked.

For instance, say you're in the furniture business. You might find that none of your competitors are targeting the millennial market on social media. There's your gap. You can then develop a social media strategy to engage millennials with modern furniture designs and grow your customer base.

A deep dive into your competitors' social media might uncover some struggling businesses. Here's where potential opportunities for acquisitions or mergers could come up. By merging with or acquiring these businesses, you could expand your operation, improve your product quality, and tap into their distribution network to reach new markets.

In conclusion, a social media competitor analysis isn't just a "nice-to-have" for your social media strategy; it's a vital tool that can steer your business in the right direction, help you stay ahead of the curve, and ultimately, succeed in the marketplace.

How to Perform a Social Media Competitive Analysis

The article from [Hootsuite](#) outlines a step-by-step process for conducting a social media competitive analysis, which is a critical tool for any business wanting to excel in the online space. Here's a summary of the key points:

1. **Identify Your Competitors:** Start by listing out who your competitors are. These could be businesses that offer similar products or services, operate in the same geographical area, or target the same audience demographic. You can use social listening tools or conduct a simple Google search to identify these competitors.
2. **Choose Which Social Networks to Analyze:** Your competitors may not be active on all social networks, and neither should you. Prioritize the platforms where your target audience is most active. You could use a social media demographics guide to help identify these platforms.
3. **Analyze Your Competitors' Social Media Presence:** Look at your competitors' overall presence on each platform. How many followers do they have? How frequently do they post? What's their brand voice and personality?
4. **Evaluate Your Competitors' Content:** Study the types of content your competitors share. What gets the most likes, shares, or comments? Is it videos, images, infographics, or user-generated content? Use this information to inform your own content strategy.
5. **Measure Your Competitors' Engagement:** Look at how your competitors interact with their audience. How do they respond to comments or complaints? Do they use any specific hashtags? Do they run contests or giveaways?
6. **Track Your Competitors' Posting Frequency:** How often are your competitors posting? This can help inform your own posting strategy.
7. **Analyze Your Competitors' Audience:** This involves studying the demographic details of your competitors' followers. What's their age, gender, location, and interests?
8. **Use Tools for Social Media Competitive Analysis:** There are various tools available that can help streamline this process, such as Hootsuite, Sprout Social, or BuzzSumo.
9. **Document Your Findings:** As you gather all of this information, document it in a way that allows you to make direct comparisons between your social media performance and that of your competitors.

10. **Make Strategic Decisions:** Finally, use all this information to make strategic decisions about your own social media strategy. Maybe you need to post more frequently, diversify your content, or engage more with your audience. Whatever it is, a competitive analysis will help you spot the areas where you can improve.

SWOT Analysis

A SWOT analysis is a useful tool for evaluating the strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats related to your business – or in this context, your social media marketing strategy. Here’s how it applies to social media:

Strengths: These are the things your business does well on social media. Maybe you have a highly engaged community, your video content receives massive views, or your customer service via direct messaging is top-notch. This could also include factors like having a well-defined brand voice that resonates with your audience, or having influencers or brand advocates who regularly share your content.

Weaknesses: These are the areas where your social media marketing could use some improvement. Perhaps your post frequency is inconsistent, your engagement rate is low, or your content isn’t resonating well with your audience. Or maybe your response time to customer queries is too long. Identifying these weak points can help you devise strategies to improve them.

Opportunities: Opportunities are external factors in your business environment that could provide a boost to your social media presence. Maybe there’s an emerging social media platform where your competitors are not yet active, or a trending topic that aligns with your brand which you can capitalize on. Perhaps there are industry events, holidays, or popular hashtags related to your business that you could leverage for increased visibility.

Threats: Threats are external factors that could potentially harm your social media presence. This could be anything from changes in social media algorithms that decrease your organic reach, to negative reviews or public relations crises that emerge online. Also, it could be potential actions of your competitors – if they’re planning to launch a big social media campaign, for example, it could overshadow your own efforts.

Conducting a SWOT analysis in the context of a social media competitive analysis involves not just looking at your own strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats, but also those of your competitors. This can give you a clearer picture of where you stand in the social media landscape and help you identify ways to improve your performance and gain a competitive edge.

Remember, the goal isn’t to copy your competitors, but to understand what they’re doing well and identify areas where you can differentiate yourself.

Social Media Competitive Analysis Template



Click on the image above to open the template or click below to download the excel spreadsheet.

[Social Media Competitive Analysis \[To use the template, click the _File_tab and select_Make a copy...\]](#)

Exploring Meta Ad Library

The [Meta Ad Library](#) is a treasure trove of information about the strategies your competitors are using to reach their target audience. Here’s an exercise to get you familiar with it. We’ll be doing three searches for your competitor or a brand you are familiar with. Here’s how to do it:

Search for a Competitor: Go to the Meta Ad Library and type in the name of your competitor or a brand that you’re interested in. Browse through the ads that are currently active. What kinds of messages are they promoting? What is their call to action? How does their ad design reflect their brand identity?

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Social Media 101

- 3.1: Every Network is an Island
- 3.2: Analyzing Twitter's Evolution - BM to AM
- 3.3: What Network is on Now?
- 3.4: The ROI of Your Mother (GaryVee said it, not me)
- 3.5: Content Speaks
- 3.6: Winning Combo - Content, Marketing, and Measurement - The "See, Think, Do, Care" Framework
- 3.7: Time Management
- 3.8: We're Engaged! Aren't We?
- 3.9: Social Media Jobs. Why Understanding Basic Marketing Principles Will Put You Ahead of the Rest
- 3.10: YOLO
- 3.11: 2023 Internet Minute Infographic, by eDiscovery Today and LTMG! - eDiscovery Trends
- 3.12: Facebook a Meta

Thumbnail: Both my mother and I were trying to make time go faster. She was checking Twitter and I took photos of her, checking Twitter. What a time to be alive. (Unsplash License; [Marten Bjork](#) via [Unsplash](#))

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3.1: Every Network is an Island

Navigating your path through the terrain of social media marketing can seem daunting, particularly when deciding which social media platform is most suitable for your business. You've defined your objectives; you may be aiming to hone your skills as a social media marketer for an enterprise or leveraging your knowledge to boost your startup's growth. In either scenario, the question of "Which social media platform is the best for my business?" inevitably arises.

This is a longstanding debate, yet it's important to realize that each network carries its own significance. The choice of platform hinges not on general perceptions of 'the best', but on what best aligns with your unique business goals and fits the specific needs of your customer personas.

Social media platforms were developed with distinct objectives in mind. Facebook sought to unify individuals worldwide, LinkedIn established an avenue for professional networking, Instagram provided a platform for all age groups to capture and chronicle their significant moments. Consequently, understanding the benefits unique to each platform is vital. It's about deciding which platform offers the capabilities that best serve your business goals, aligns with your industry and resonates with your defined customer personas.

Remember the initial chapters: "What business are you in?" and "Who is your customer?" Keeping your specific industry and your target customer personas in mind is key when assessing these platforms. Each one offers unique benefits and reaches specific demographics, so consider where your customers are most likely to be active and engaged. The platform that best reaches your customers and aligns with your business objectives is the one you want to focus on.

Side Note

Regardless of whether you're a budding startup or an established brand, it's wise to secure your brand name across all social media networks, even if you're not actively using them in your current strategy. This preemptive measure ensures your brand name isn't hijacked or misused by others. The last thing you want is for someone else to lay claim to your brand's name.

Who Lives There?

A primary appeal of social media for marketers is the extensive targeting options it provides. Unlike traditional marketing which often focuses on mass marketing, social media marketing allows you to precisely target the audience for your marketing campaigns.

Before launching any marketing campaign, it's essential to set clear goals, including defining the type of audience who should view your ads and how they should interact with your business. For this, it's essential to know the demographics of users on each social platform. Let's talk Statistics for a bit.

Find more statistics at [Statista](https://www.statista.com/)

Facebook is populated mostly by adults of 25-34 years age group. The second largest group is 18-24 years who make up 23.8% of Facebook's population and only 4.8% of users fall into the senior age group. The biggest country present on the platform is India, while users from the US and Canada are only 10% of the total Facebook population. As for gender, males dominate the platform with 56% of the total population. Also, 51% active users visit the website several times a day and 75% of Facebook users are at least college graduates.

Instagram

On Instagram, the highest population is of 25-34 year olds who make up 33.1% of all users and age group of 18-24 years is second with 29.6% share. Most of them come from the US, whereas India and Brazil hold second and third positions respectively. 43% of these users are college graduates and 42% earn over \$75,000 per annum.

Over 510 million users are females and males are behind with a difference of 20 million. These users spend around 28 minutes a day on Insta. Most users follow at least a single brand on the app and 73% of teens in the US find Instagram the easiest way to reach and interact with a brand.

TikTok

TikTok is a customer favorite app and stands second among the most popular free apps of 2019. Its users are present in 141 countries while China, India, United States, and Turkey are among the countries where it is more frequently downloaded and used.

44% TikTok users are females and 56% are males. Out of these, 41% users are aged 16-24 years who spend at least 52 minutes every day on the app, watching videos related to entertainment, dance, pranks, fitness and other categories.

90% of TikTok or Douyin users access the app via Android smartphones and maintain a healthy engagement rate of 52%. In 2019, people spent \$115.3 million on the app for in-app purchases, influencer marketing, etc.

This was a brief overview of some popular social platforms. You can opt for the platform that suits your business needs.

What Language Do They Speak?

Whether you're talking to friends in a party, communicating with little kids in social gatherings, or sharing thoughts with business associates in a professional setting, you should always be aware of your audience. When you choose the language or tone they understand, you can conveniently communicate with each other without misunderstandings.

Don't forget this rule when communicating with your audience on social media. Creating a profile on social websites is easy. What's difficult is to spread your message and get people talking about the brand in a positive manner. However, this objective can be achieved by determining what type of content the audience prefers and creating posts accordingly.

Hashtags (#)

Hashtags were introduced by Chris Messina in an attempt to organize content on social media. Twitter platform first introduced this unique feature in 2007, but it was later adopted by Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, Pinterest, and LinkedIn due to its usability.

A hashtag categorizes content on the basis of topic. If you want to reach the right audience for your business, you need to target popular and relevant ones. Moreover, you can also create custom hashtags to promote your products.

Let's discuss this concept with an example. Imagine that a roofing service provider hires you as a social media marketer. To build their business online, you need to come up with suitable hashtags for the social marketing strategy. Here are a few trends and hashtags that may prove useful:

#roofing #roofingcontractor #construction #greenroofing #roofrepair #roofgutters

Long Form vs. Short Form Content

The internet users tend to have short attention spans. They easily get distracted and can ignore your posts if they don't find it interesting. This is why content marketing in digital media focuses on captivating and concise content that can keep readers hooked till the last line.

If we need to keep the content short, how can we share important information or news with the target audience?

It's common for social media marketers to get confused about the length of content. But you should remember that the content length depends on the interest of your audience as well as the platform where you intend to post it.

If you are planning to set up a company blog, it's best to opt for long-form content. The purpose of blogging is to educate people about a relevant topic and offer comprehensive solutions to problems. For example, if you are an expert in providing electrical installation and repair services, you may want to write posts about safety tips for customers. Blog posts can be 500-1,000 words, but you should aim for publishing blogs of 2,000-2,500 words to boost SEO score.

LinkedIn is also suitable for posting long-form content. You can write about your area of expertise and experiences to share knowledge with other professionals.

Other social platforms such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, etc. may be suitable for short-term content. Whether you are thinking of creating text posts, videos, or images, it's a better option to keep the content short for better engagement.

Also, don't forget that long form videos aren't compatible with most social websites. Instagram supports videos of up to 15 seconds. So, if you are creating long form informative videos, it may be a good option to post it on YouTube and share a brief snippet on Twitter and other social websites. Your followers who find the topic interesting will visit your YouTube channel to watch the entire video.

What's Their Favorite Dish?

Back in the day, social media marketing was all about text posts and still images. With technology advancements, a wide variety of content is now available to internet users. Let's first take a look at the most popular types of digital content. After that, we will discuss which content goes well with popular social websites.

- Blogs or articles
- eBooks
- Images (still images, GIFs, 360° images)
- Videos (recorded videos and live streaming)
- Infographics
- Testimonials
- Contests
- Polls
- Podcasts
- Webinars
- How-to guides

Instagram is an image-based platform. To promote your brand, you can share high-quality images of products, team members, as well as stills from networking events. Adding relevant captions and hashtags is also essential. A similar strategy is suitable for **Pinterest** where you can capture attention via images.

As for **Facebook**, videos perform far better than any other type of content. This includes live streams as well as processed images for coverage of organizational events. You can also post videos developed with the aim of advertising on your Facebook page.

With the increasing population of **TikTok**, you shouldn't ignore its importance in the marketing plan. You can complement videos with captions and can include links to your website to increase web traffic.

Twitter network is known for its credibility when it comes to news and information. Users of this platform show more interest in professionally processed content which includes informational infographics and videos.

For **LinkedIn**, you can turn to long form articles, user guides, and eBooks to increase engagement. We all know **YouTube** is one of the most popular video streaming websites. So, you can post videos on this platform regardless of their size or length.

Reading

<https://www.oberlo.com/blog/social-media-marketing-statistics>

<https://backlinko.com/social-media-users>

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3.2: Analyzing Twitter's Evolution - BM to AM

Discussing Twitter is a necessity, even if its demise seems imminent. The platform's significance in communication, news sharing and societal movements since its establishment remains noteworthy. Essentially, we should analyze it during two eras: before Elon Musk (BM) and after his acquisition (AM).

Presently viewed as a colossal disaster under Musk's ownership, Twitter's integrity has suffered. Launching with mass firings of developers and alienating advertisers to the point where major companies retracted their support—despite not being an optimal advertising choice compared to Facebook, Instagram or Google—Twitter was still patronized due to its large audience base.

Musk intended for Twitter users to freely voice their opinions without censorship despite his controversial business tactics leading many to dub the situation as a “dumpster fire.” Though you can interact with acquaintances on the platform, engaging becomes more challenging due primarily to bots proliferating hate speech and explicit content.

The decline in active users is evident; most only log in occasionally for mentions or event interactions via sponsors that maintain accounts there. However, sustaining such activity increasingly becomes burdensome.



However, to appreciate Twitter's true potential, we need to look back to the era before Musk. This was a time when Twitter's original purpose, as encapsulated by co-founder Biz Stone, was at its purest.



In a series of captivating anecdotes from Twitter co-founder Biz Stone at the Cannes Lions 2009, the birth, growth, and global impact of Twitter are traced. Born out of the inspirations from simplicity and ease of communication present in platforms like AOL Instant Messenger, Twitter grew into a real-time communication network, facilitating an intriguing sense of connection among users. Initially, the allure of Twitter was the real-time updates, as mundane as they may be, lending an intriguing peek into the lives of others.

A remarkable example includes a tweet from Stone announcing a pub change that led to the new pub reaching its capacity within 10 minutes. This showcased Twitter's ability to facilitate group coordination in real-time, akin to a flock of birds moving as a single unit. This potential was also visible when Twitter's presence at a festival created a buzz and brought people together.

Twitter's potential extended beyond casual coordination, manifesting in profound impacts on journalism and activism. One example saw a man in Egypt using Twitter to document protests, demonstrating how social media could capture and spread significant moments globally. Furthermore, a single-word tweet even managed to secure legal assistance for someone in trouble, exemplifying Twitter's potential to affect real-world change.

The platform itself, however, wasn't just about technology but also about the triumph of humanity. As seen in instances where Twitter was used to coordinate efforts during wildfires, gas shortages, breaking news events, and natural disasters, the platform

proved to be a facilitator for collective human action.

The notion of collective action is further strengthened by Twitter's open network and ecosystem, fostering growth and diversification on a global scale. By opening its infrastructure to developers, Twitter sparked the creation of over 11,000 registered applications that generate three times the traffic of twitter.com itself. This approach allowed Twitter to tap into the power of billions of mobile and internet users globally, creating a potentially impactful and unpredictable open network.

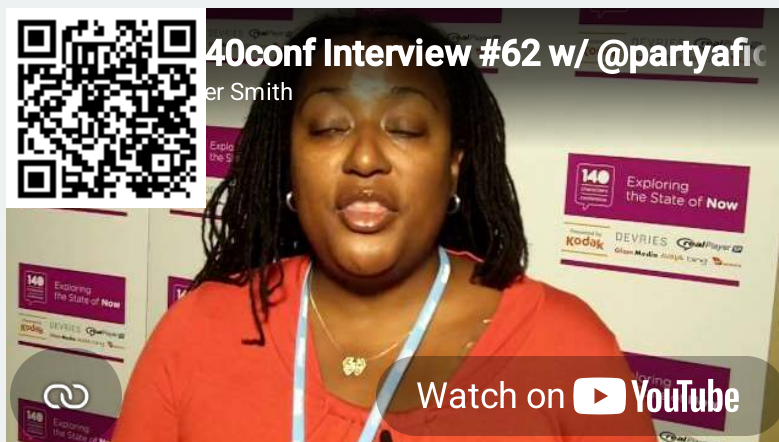
On the commercial side, Twitter has proven to be a valuable tool for businesses, leading to increased revenue and customer engagement. Brands used Twitter for customer service, monitoring customer complaints and providing immediate responses. Even small businesses could stay connected with local customers without incurring substantial costs, by using Twitter for marketing and customer service.

Stone's recounting of Twitter's history not only presents the platform as a means of communication and information sharing but also as an instrument of global connectivity and collective action. The ability for businesses to leverage this platform for commercial gain is significant, but equally, if not more important, is the potential of Twitter, or any social media platform, to address complex global challenges by fostering a culture of collaboration, openness, and interoperability.

📌 on a personal note

On a personal note, I am deeply saddened by Twitter's dramatic decline since Musk acquired the company in October 2022. Twitter was my favorite social network, primarily because of the conversations and connections it facilitated. I fondly recall receiving an email from then-Senator Barack Obama, inviting me to join him on this new platform. It was a thrilling era, seeing politicians and news outlets begin to leverage the power of social media.

In 2009/10, Jeff Pulver initiated the 140 conference (named after Twitter's character limit at the time), bringing together enthusiasts who recognized Twitter's potential to connect the world. This inspired me to launch the SMTULSA Conference to unite social media enthusiasts in my own region.

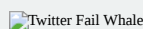


Twitter changed the trajectory of my career/personal brand.

1. My dog's Twitter account [@imajackrussell](#) brought me speaking gigs, and sponsorships
2. I created and sustained the annual [SMTULSA Conference](#) for 10 years & it all started with Twitter.

Today, my visits to Twitter are limited to learning about new AI tools and receiving local weather updates through the #okwx hashtag, which remains invaluable for Oklahoma residents. However, the majority of my time is now spent on platforms like TikTok, YouTube, and as of yesterday, (July 2023) Instagram's new Twitter competitor, Threads. We'll delve into the rise of these emerging social platforms later, but for now, it's a solemn farewell to the Twitter we once knew.

The good old days were when the worst thing that happened on Twitter was the 'fail whale'.



Twitter Fail Whale

Enough with the nostalgia about Twitter. It's probably evident from my reminiscing that it held a special place in my heart during the BM era. However, let's shift our focus back to the present. If you're considering Twitter as a part of your brand or project's social media strategy, I have a couple of valuable exercises to help you learn how to effectively leverage the platform.

? Exercise

Exercise 1: Live Tweet a YouTube Video

Objective: To enhance your ability to create compelling, real-time content and learn how to incorporate relevant hashtags effectively.

Steps:

1. Choose an interesting and relevant video from YouTube. This could be related to your industry, a motivational talk, or a tutorial – anything that provides value to your audience.
2. As you watch the video, compose live tweets that summarize key points, insights, or interesting facts. Remember, each tweet is a standalone message, so it should be comprehensible on its own.
3. Incorporate the official hashtag in your tweets. This could be the video title, the speaker's name, the event hashtag (ie: #TedxTulsa) or the topic being discussed.
4. Engage with your audience. If they reply to your tweets or ask questions, respond promptly and keep the conversation going.

This exercise not only helps you understand the dynamics of live-tweeting but also enables you to observe how your audience engages with different types of content.

Exercise 2: Twitter for Search – #ai

Objective: To explore the power of Twitter as a search tool and identify valuable content in your area of interest.

Steps:

1. Log in to your Twitter account or visit <https://twitter.com/explore>
2. In the search bar at the top, enter the hashtag #ai and press enter.
3. Browse through the resulting tweets to identify threads or individual tweets that catch your attention.
4. Look for content that provides new insights, challenges your thinking, or offers a fresh perspective on artificial intelligence.
5. Retweet your favorite thread or tweet, and consider adding a comment of your own to spark conversation.
6. Make a note of any new influencers, thought leaders, or interesting accounts you come across during your search.
7. This exercise will help you realize the vast amount of information available on Twitter, and how effectively using hashtags can streamline your search for quality content. Caution! Due to the increased prevalence of spam and inappropriate content on Twitter, particularly after Elon Musk's acquisition (AM), your search results may include potentially offensive tweets. For this reason, it's not recommended to conduct this exercise via a projected screen.

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3.3: What Network is on Now?

Digital marketing strategy plays a critical role in business growth. With the right strategy, you can raise brand awareness, attract the target audience, and build lasting relationships for a win-win situation. However, your marketing efforts can prove fruitful only if you understand how to use social platforms to your advantage.

Social media has become a part of our lives. Successful marketers put themselves in customers' shoes and choose a strategy that focuses on their pain points. If you want to increase the efficacy of your digital marketing campaigns, you need to learn about popular social media websites.

While a myriad of social media websites is available these days, you can't promote your brand on each and every website. By focusing your efforts on websites that are popular among your audience, you can drive results.

Why Do You Want One to Win Or Lose?

Myspace got the first-mover advantage and remained the leading social website for quite some time. However, when Facebook was introduced, it captured a huge market share in no time and left other social media websites struggling with their loss.

When an innovative company is launched with the right strategy, it has a good chance of eliminating the predecessor and becoming the market leader. In the past, we have seen many such examples. Netflix beat Blockbuster, digital camera companies killed Polaroid, and Circuit City lost to Best Buy.

This is a common trend that old and established businesses lose to new market entrants. It is because many traditional stores prefer to stick with the strategies and actions they have been using for years and fear change or innovation.

This practice isn't good for anyone; neither marketers nor consumers. If there is no market competition, consumers would suffer the most.

Higher competition eliminates the monopoly. The more firms in the market, the more efforts would be needed for a business to make its place in the crowded market. They are motivated to innovate and offer value to consumers to stand out. It keeps them on toes and they constantly put in their best efforts to stay ahead and stay relevant. Similarly, they are also inclined to offer better quality goods and services at reasonable prices.

Now, let's consider the example of social media in this scenario. It's best for everyone that the competition is increasing amongst social media companies. The more the competition, the higher will be the service quality at lower rates. So, whether you use the internet for personal networking or you are a business marketer, this competition will benefit you in the long run.

How Do We Benefit From Each Network?

Investing time and money in social media is no longer optional for business marketers. With your competition gaining customers and building a good reputation via social websites, you can't afford to miss out on this invaluable opportunity.

As marketers, your first step should be to get a website where you can display products, testimonials, and other relevant information. After that, you can gain several benefits from social accounts.

Regardless of which platform you choose, you can raise awareness via social posts as well as paid social media advertising. Your social posts should include a CTA that guides users about the next action. For instance, if you post a special discount for your social media followers, you ought to add the link to the online store where they can redeem it.

Customers tend to trust businesses that have a transparent system. Not only should you share detailed information about your business, but also share accurate pricing and terms and conditions. With this approach, you can earn their trust.

Many customers post reviews about their experiences with a brand. When a satisfied customer posts a positive comment, you should respond to them. However, it's equally important to respond to negative comments. When you take action quickly to solve their problems, your popularity and sales are likely to elevate.

What's Hot Right Now?

Being a marketer, you should be well-aware of current market trends. It will help you stay relevant and update your marketing strategy accordingly to reach your audience. On the other hand, if you don't know which social media marketing channels are the most popular, you may lose customer attention before you know it.

With people confined to home due to COVID, the use of the internet, especially social media has significantly increased. A majority of people interact with their friends and families via social media. The use of digital media and social platforms for business purposes has also become the norm. So, you need to know which platforms are hot these days and which ones are losing popularity.

The trends for 2020 are out now and marketers can develop a strategy for 2021 based on these statistics. Here is a list of top social websites along with the number of active users on these sites.

- Facebook – 2,701 million
- YouTube – 2,000 million
- WhatsApp – Facebook – 2,000 million
- Facebook Messenger – 1,300 million
- WeChat – 1,206 million
- Instagram – 1,158 million
- TikTok – 689 million

If you don't currently use the aforementioned sites for marketing purposes, it's time to go through your social marketing strategy again and revise the strategy to adjust to these trends.

Let's Explore

Whether you are promoting a new business or working with a business that has been in the industry for a long time, you need an effective marketing strategy for social channels.

In social marketing, there are no rules and standards. You can't follow specific rules that guarantee to meet objectives. The best way to succeed in the social media world is to adopt the trial and error technique. You should come up with a plan to promote the brand and execute it on social channels of your choice. If it brings you the desired results, then it's great! But there is a good chance that social marketing efforts won't always prove effective.

Despite your efforts to boost awareness, gain customers, or generate leads, your social strategy won't always work. This is why it's important to have a contingency plan. If the first plan doesn't get results, you should adjust it based on the performance metrics.

The good thing is that there are several options available for marketers. If Facebook doesn't work, you may turn to LinkedIn for the next campaign. You should set clear objectives, choose the right platform that meets your criteria, and measure performance after the execution of the social marketing plan for making your social marketing campaigns fruitful.

Further Reading

<https://sproutsocial.com/insights/social-media-marketing-strategy/>

<https://www.socialmediaexaminer.com/social-media-marketing-trends-2021-predictions-from-pros/>

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3.4: The ROI of Your Mother (GaryVee said it, not me)

Digital marketing is a must for businesses in this era. It's because around 60% of the world's population is present on the internet. Your competitors are likely advertising on digital platforms and interacting with their target audience via social media. So, you may end up losing these precious prospective customers.

Social media has become a part of our lives. Whether you want to talk to friends or build business networks, social platforms are the way to go. With targeted social ads, you can effectively run campaigns to increase brand awareness, increase traffic to your official business website, convert visitors into customers, or engage the existing customer base. If you want to make the most of these platforms, you can't ignore analytics.

Gary Vaynerchuk, commonly known as Gary Vee is the king of digital marketing. During a corporate meeting, he was enquired multiple times about the ROI of social media campaigns at his company. When the top executive manager kept asking the same question, he gave back with a question of his own: "What's the ROI of your mother?"

While it may seem a personal attack to many, Gary Vee actually raised a great point. Being the marketing genius that he is, he highlighted the importance of context and efforts when it comes to social marketing.

He shared this memory in a 2011 event. At that time, not many tools were present to calculate the return on investment for social media campaigns. He implied that it's not possible to measure the ROI of his mother, but it reflects in his achievements. If his mother didn't encourage him to be his best and boost his self-esteem, he wouldn't be able to reach where he is today. To be precise, it's not easy to calculate the exact ROI of certain things, but it doesn't mean those things aren't valuable.

With time, businesses became more familiar with social marketing and a myriad of tools and metrics are now available to marketers. Therefore, he rephrased his earlier claims in 2015 and enlightened us with the fact that the ROI of social marketing can be measured and it's important to keep track of these performance indicators.

ROI of a tool is directly proportional to the time and efforts you invest in mastering it. For instance, the ROI of you playing basketball may be zero or a few hundred dollars if you bet on games. But a game of basketball will have a much higher worth for LeBron James considering that he earns over \$39 million per annum salary, excluding sponsorship deals and other income. It is only because he spent years learning the game and investing in improving his skills.

The same goes for social platforms. If you keep investing in social media marketing and build your brand online through aggressive organic and paid marketing, then the ROI will go up in the future.

Increasing the ROI of Social Marketing Campaigns

Social marketing works best when you create long-term goals instead of focusing on short-term benefits. Your marketing campaigns should align with the organization's vision and promote a positive image. Moreover, you should also define clear objectives you intend to achieve with social marketing campaigns. This way, you can increase the monetary and non-monetary revenue earned against these efforts.

Time

Regardless of which business you start, it will take time for the business to become a success. You ought to build networks, create goodwill, expand the customer base, and improve cash flows. Social marketing is no different.

You need to spend a lot of time understanding the social world. Once you have set up business profiles on social platforms of your choice, you have to come up with the right content strategy. You need to learn who your ideal audience is and create content as per their interests. You also need to determine what your competitors are doing differently and learn from them.

Your social marketing efforts may not give much ROI during the initial days or even months. But if you come up with an effective plan, things will start getting better with time. So, keep exploring the world of social marketing and your brand will eventually grow online with time and efforts.

Money

It's a prevalent myth that social media is free. Let me clear this misconception for you. Social platforms aren't free for businesses or even individuals. You spend your precious time chatting with friends and scrolling the timeline when you could have spent it doing more important tasks. So, you pay the price in the form of time.

However, it's important to remember that businesses shouldn't only rely on organic social marketing for growth. Social media ads are extremely helpful in meeting goals. Not only are they relatively cost-effective as compared to traditional marketing channels, but they also offer better targeting options.

Businesses spend millions on social ads, but you can invest in these ads as per your budget. There are a myriad of targeting options available and you can reach the audience based on their gender, location, interests, devices, online activities, behaviors, demographics, and many more specific options.

Furthermore, you can also run marketing campaigns for the audience depending on their buyer's journey stage:

- **Awareness Stage** – Brand Awareness and Reach
- **Consideration Stage** – Traffic, Engagement, App Installs, Video Views, Lead Generation, Messages
- **Conversion Stage** – Conversions, Catalogue Sales, Store foot Traffic

Analytics Tools for Social Media ROI

You can spend significant amounts of time and money in building social profiles and running comprehensive ad campaigns. But how would you know whether your efforts bring the desired results?

The best way to track your social ad campaigns is through analytics tools. You can find various tools and software that provide useful information. With the help of this data, you can optimize your social media strategy and meet predefined marketing goals.

So, here are some of the best analytics tools that may prove the right choice for you:

Hubspot Marketing Analytics

Hubspot Marketing Analytics dashboard offers a unique solution for your social marketing needs. It tracks the ROI of ad campaigns on any social platform, assists you with creating Calls-to-Action that drive results, guides you about the best SEO strategies, and lets you create attractive landing pages for lead generation.

Google Analytics

With Google leading the tech industry, it's no surprise that their social media analytics tool is also one of the best options out there. It is compatible with Google partner platforms including YouTube. You can also integrate it with your business website to monitor website traffic. You can determine how much traffic each social platform directs towards your website and find out detailed information such as engagement, bounce rate, conversion rate, etc.

Mention

Mention is an innovative tool through which you can find out how your brand is doing online. It informs you about discussions related to your brand and lets you know what your customers are saying about you. You can also use this tool to learn about your competitors and take appropriate actions to further improve your social presence.

Keyhole

If your social marketing strategy revolves around Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram, then Keyhole may be the ultimate solution for you. Not only can you explore the performance of social campaigns, but also find out when your target audience is online and how they engage with social posts. You can also learn about reach, impressions, engagement, and conversion from individual posts as well as the entire ads campaign.

Aside from these standalone tools, you can also utilize analytics dashboard offered by different social platforms. They include Twitter Analytics, Facebook Insights, LinkedIn Analytics, Pinterest Analytics, last but not the least YouTube Analytics.

Further Reading

[Social Media Analytics: 12 Hidden Reports to See if Your Social Strategy is Working \(neilpatel.com\)](https://neilpatel.com/blog/social-media-analytics-12-hidden-reports-to-see-if-your-social-strategy-is-working/)

Video:



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3.5: Content Speaks

Social media and content go hand-in-hand. The purpose of creating social media websites was to provide users a platform where they can interact with each other and share information. Being a marketer, you can't ignore the value of content. Hence it goes without saying that you need a content marketing strategy for social platforms.

Many companies post content on social websites without a documented strategy to back their actions. A well-documented strategy and plan streamlines actions and guides you in the right direction. It helps you stay on track towards long-term and short-term goals and get heard.

To create an effective content strategy, ask yourself the following questions:

- What are my goals?
- Who should I post content for?
- Which platforms would work best?
- What type of content is preferred by my audience?
- How often should I post content?
- Which KPIs should I use for measuring performance?

Creating Your “Voice”

Brand voice is the distinct personality of your business that sets you apart from the competition. It creates an image or perception in customers' minds. If you promote a positive message through a captivating brand voice, then it won't be difficult for you to achieve social media marketing goals through your unique brand voice.

On social media, you can attract the audience through storytelling. Your stories should portray a consistent image to build credibility. For instance, if you are an optimistic person in real life, you notice the positive aspect of every event and don't linger in the negativity. Similarly, if you intend to portray your brand as adventurous, energetic, inspiring, or trustworthy, you should choose a tone that portrays this image and be consistent.

Customers consider the brand image of a business before they interact with them or make buying decisions. If your brand voice is intimidating or you often post controversial content, then you may end up losing them to more stable and friendly competitors.

Where to Find the Right Content?

Creating fresh content takes time and effort. If you engage with your audience on multiple social websites, it won't be easy to generate unique content for every platform especially when you need to post content on a regular basis. Amidst the coronavirus outbreak, getting new ideas and creating unique content has become even more difficult. This is when content repurposing comes into the picture.

It's a good idea to look at content generated by other social media users. You can get to know about the latest trends and get ideas for your business. An example is that you can work on some DIY projects and record the procedure via a time-lapse video to engage the audience.

You may have created some evergreen content in the past. Go check your social profiles and locate posts that can be reused. For example, you may find images posted on Pinterest or Instagram from previous vacations. You can create blog posts about your experiences around those images and post them on your blog. However, when repurposing the content, make sure it goes well with your brand voice and the general language of the specific social website.

You should also consider creating content around the products your business offers. You can create whitepapers to share detailed information about the product or process. It's also a good idea to complement it with a how-to article or video to educate customers.

Content repurposing works great when you understand your weaknesses and strengths. If you aren't good at talking in front of a camera, then creating videos for social media may not be your best bet. Stammering out of nervousness portrays a negative image. You should rather choose platforms that go well with your personality and can help you promote your entrepreneurial venture.

Now that the world is moving towards online business, e-conferencing has become a norm. You can conduct business meetings as well as events via Zoom or other digital platforms. You should consider recording such online events and posting them on social media.

How to Create the Right Content?

As a marketer, you can learn from social media trends popular among other business people. Event marketing has become quite popular these days where professionals meet and communicate with each other about topics of mutual interest. These events provide you an opportunity to create engaging content for your social media audience.

You should consider recording these events and posting them on social media for the followers. You can record videos via any device, but you may wonder whether it's better to share live and unprocessed videos or should you process them first before posting on social media. I would say both tactics can work in your favor.

In the case of live events, social media users expect to enjoy live coverage of the event. If you don't want them to miss those golden moments, you should live broadcast the event on your social media pages. Facebook Live feature comes in handy for this purpose.

Back in the day, it was believed that brands may suffer if they share unprocessed video content with the audience as they are less attractive to viewers. But this isn't the case anymore. People don't mind this approach because they are aware you may not always have professional equipment at hand when attending a business event. Moreover, people today are more interested in authentic brands. Overly processed content leads to question marks on authenticity, which is why live videos should be added to your social media content strategy.

It's also important to remember that posting live videos doesn't mean processed and professional quality videos aren't important. You can share the event live and process captured images and videos for later use. With this professional content, you can promote the brand, product, or event on an on-going basis. So, we can say that a combination of raw/live videos and processed videos works best for many businesses.

What Tools Do You Need?

Social media content creation may seem a difficult task but it's no rocket science. You don't need to invest a huge sum in buying equipment and tools to create the right content.

Many marketers avoid generating video content for social media because they don't own professional equipment. However, you don't need highly professional cameras to record videos. It's perfectly fine to use a smartphone camera, digital cam, or GoPro for capturing events. But it's recommended to get a portable tripod to ensure captured videos are stable and clear.

In the indoor environment, you may need to arrange lighting equipment. However, outdoor events can save you from this trouble too. Also, don't forget to get a microphone to record audio along with the video content.

If you intend to share it live, you need not process it to enhance quality, but it's important to edit and process them for professionally posting them on LinkedIn and other platforms.

There are many video editing software available that you can learn to use. However, it is a complex process that is best left to professionals. To find qualified professionals, you should visit Freelancer.com and Upwork websites. These are popular freelancing platforms where you can hire professionals on a project basis or an on-going as per your needs.

The Caption Game?

Posting images and videos on Instagram and other websites isn't enough; you should complement it with captivating captions to increase engagement. Its length can vary, but Insta supports captions of up to 2,200 words. The shorter the text, the more effective it will be.

For your persona profile, you may add a quote that comes to your mind. But business branding shouldn't be done this way. You should write a concise caption that represents the brand personality and resonates with your followers.

Writing long-form captions can work for brands as long as they aren't boring. If you want to adopt this method, always remember to mention important phrases or words at the beginning. This way, when the post is truncated, users will still be able to get the information at a glance.

Aside from the descriptive text, you should also add the most appropriate hashtags to increase visibility.

What's the Hashtag?

A hashtag is a combination of letters or numbers that represent a specific topic. It's helpful for users because it helps them organize content and view posts based on their interests or the latest trends. You can follow hashtags that attract you the most so as to easily access information about that topic.

These hashtags are widely used on TikTok, Instagram, Twitter, and many other popular websites. As a marketer, you should up your game and master the art of creating and using the right hashtags to better promote your brand and products online.

You can use an existing hashtag or create a new one around your business or business event. On TikTok, brands often create viral challenges and come up with suitable hashtags for these challenge videos. You can follow in their footsteps and create a challenge of your own to get customer attention.

You can brainstorm to come up with innovative hashtags for business marketing, but hashtag tools can simplify this task for you. It's recommended to explore Hashtagify, RiteTag, Trendsmap, and AutoHash to master the art of hashtagging.

Ask Your 8-Year-Old

Social media strategy gives the desired results when it's focused on the needs of target customers. So, brands that create content that attracts their followers tend to get more views and can maintain a good conversion rate.

The population on social media is constantly increasing and more and more youngsters are creating profiles on social media. Therefore, the best way to understand what kind of content these people need is to get the opinion of kids and teenagers.

These youngsters are well-equipped with modern technology and understand how to use almost any platform. They can guide you about the content that attracts this young generation and even give you unique ideas to make your content more engaging.

With the help of these insights, you can develop a plan to increase the engagement rate and convince the audience to take action.

Is that Wrong? The Ethical Question in Social Media

Remember when Adidas faced a backlash by tweeting the following message to participants who completed the Boston annual race in 2018, due to its reference to painful Boston bombings at the 2013 event?

"Congrats, you survived the Boston Marathon!"

Or when the skincare company, Nivea, posted a social media ad emphasizing that "White is Purity"?

Many businesses grab the headlines from time to time due to a simple mistake on social media or due to their inappropriate posts. It's a growing concern among social media users and can bring negative publicity to businesses.

Before you post content on social media, make sure it's free of profanities, culturally inappropriate language, racism, or other negative aspects that can cause controversy. You need to respect everyone regardless of their beliefs, ethnic background, financial status, or sexual orientation, and create content that doesn't harm anyone's feelings. With an ethical approach, you can effectively promote your brand and build a positive brand image.

Am I Famous Yet?

Social media marketing is a cost-efficient yet effective way to promote your products and reach out to the audience. A common mistake made by some marketers is that they post content and ads on social media for a few days and opt out of social marketing if the posts go unnoticed.

There is no doubt that social media websites have become the leading platforms for marketing purposes. However, it doesn't mean that your brand will suddenly become popular in a few days.

Nowadays, a majority of businesses rely on social media marketing. Under such circumstances, you can't expect to become the market leader within a week.

What you need to do is to be consistent with your effort. During the initial few weeks, your social marketing campaigns may not do that great. However, you should follow the marketing strategy without losing hope. Furthermore, monitoring the performance of the campaign is also essential. It can guide you about what you are doing right and which areas of your social marketing need to be changed.

With this approach, your social marketing efforts will bring results in time and can become the customer choice through constant efforts.

 Reading

<https://buffer.com/resources/repurposing-content-guide/>

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3.6: Winning Combo - Content, Marketing, and Measurement - The "See, Think, Do, Care" Framework

Introducing [Avinash Kaushik's "See, Think, Do, Care" framework](#) – a snappy, innovative strategy to understand your customer's journey and align it with your social and digital content. Imagine it as a cycle that your customers are constantly flowing through, with each stage reflecting a different state of mind, a different need, a different level of engagement.

Here's a brief rundown

See: This is the largest possible audience, all the folks out there who could potentially be interested in your products or services. They may not know they need your product yet, but we're trying to catch their eye.

Think: This is a subset of the "See" crowd. These are the people who are actively thinking about a product or service like yours, but haven't quite made the decision to purchase yet.

Do: Now we're getting into serious territory. This group is smaller still, made up of people who are ready to make a move. They're ready to buy, subscribe, download, you name it.

Care: This last group is the cream of the crop. These are your most loyal customers. They've bought, they're happy, and they're likely to do it again. Not only that, but they're also likely to tell their friends about how great you are.

Now, how do we tackle content for each of these stages? This is where the fun begins. Each stage requires a different approach.

 See Think Do Care photo by Cheryl Lawson 2014 Demand Success Conference

The image illustrates Avinash Kaushik's See-Think-Do-Care framework applied to a specific audience. Travel & Adventure Business

See-Think-Do-Care framework for Social Media Content

The beauty of the See-Think-Do-Care framework lies in its versatility and applicability to virtually any content marketing strategy, including social media. It provides a clear roadmap to content creation, helping you address the unique needs of audiences at different stages in their customer journey. Let's break down how to use it in your social media strategy:

See: At this stage, your aim is to raise awareness and attract potential customers. Content here should be engaging, informative, and shareable, but it doesn't need to directly promote your product or service. Think of blog posts, infographics, and videos that answer common questions or solve problems in your industry. Share this content on your social platforms to attract a broad audience, gain followers, and build your brand reputation.

Think: Here, your audience is contemplating their options. They're aware of their needs and are actively seeking solutions. Your social media content should guide them towards your offerings without being overly promotional. Case studies, customer testimonials, product comparison posts, and 'how-to' content that features your product or service can be effective here. This type of content can help sway their opinion in your favor and push them further down the funnel.

Do: At this stage, your audience is ready to take action. They've done their research, they've weighed their options, and they're ready to make a decision. The content here should be targeted, direct, and persuasive, with clear calls to action. Offer exclusive discounts, highlight the unique selling points of your product or service, share product demos, or promote free trials.

Care: This stage is all about nurturing and retaining your existing customers. Engage with your loyal customers on social media by sharing user-generated content, offering exclusive promotions or sneak peeks at new products, and asking for their input on upcoming features or products. Your goal here is to keep them interested and engaged with your brand, transforming them into brand advocates.

By understanding and implementing the See-Think-Do-Care framework, you can ensure that your social media content marketing is hitting all the necessary touchpoints, effectively guiding your audience from awareness to conversion, and beyond.

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3.7: Time Management

Social media is a great tool for promoting your business without breaking the bank, but it can become a nuisance if you aren't careful. Working as a social media marketer can be a tough job if you constantly feel the urge to scroll the timeline every now and then.

Furthermore, social marketing tends to be a time-consuming task. Without an effective plan, you will end up wasting time and won't be able to achieve your goals.

A major reason why marketers fail to use social media to their advantage is that they try to be on every social network. This is neither possible nor a good idea. Regardless of whether you work on your own or have a social media team, it's important to choose social websites that fit your goal. This way, you can save precious time by putting your entire focus on social accounts that can increase website traffic and generate results.

Another challenge for social marketers is to stay focused on work when logging into social media accounts for job-related tasks. You may soon find yourself checking posts and messages from other users. The best strategy to tackle this issue and manage time is to set time limits for every task. For instance, if you need to post a tweet, you should specify the time needed for the task. With the deadline approaching, you will be motivated to prioritize work and avoid indulging in time-wasting activities.

When you are responsible to manage multiple social media accounts, it's not easy to keep track of the password for each account. You can neither write it down on a piece of paper due to security risks nor use the same password for every account.

The best way to avoid wasting time looking for passwords is to use password management software. These tools save credentials in a safe way and enable marketers to log in to different accounts without an issue. Moreover, when you need to check social media profiles via any other device, all you need to do is to access your password manager account and it will provide you access in no time.

Practice Safe Scheduling

Behind every successful job is plenty of planning. To succeed as a social marketer, you need to plan the actions you need to take for running marketing campaigns.

Your priority should be to get a content planning calendar for your business. You can easily find a template online or design a calendar that best fits your requirements. With the help of this tool, you can specify the content that needs to be posted across platforms.

In organizations, social media marketers usually plan content for a month in advance. You can make slight changes to this calendar on the go based on current events. You can decide the theme of the day or week and plan which type of content should be posted on different platforms throughout the month. This practice makes sure you can regularly post content for business promotion. If you work with a team of social media marketers, it will be easier to keep them in the loop.

When you track the performance of social media campaigns, you will get to know when the majority of your audience is online and can post content accordingly. But what if that time slot isn't during standard business hours and you can't log in at that particular time? This is when scheduling tools will save you from trouble.

SocialPilot, HootSuite, Post Planner, Feedly, and other similar tools can be used to schedule social media posts for a later date or time. You won't have to worry about forgetting to post content and the software will take care of this task.

That's Embarrassing: Don't Let Your Scheduled Post Land at the Wrong Party

Scheduling social media posts via software can make things easier for you and boost productivity. However, this method isn't fool-proof and can lead to embarrassing mistakes if you aren't cautious.

Some brands become the talk of the town in a negative way when they accidentally post content with unintentional profanities. Sephora once created a hashtag "#C**tdownToBeauty" when they actually wanted to use the hashtag #CountdownToBeauty. This mistake can happen when you schedule a post for later without proofreading it. It's ideal to update settings for filtering out unethical phrases and words.

US Airways and a few other businesses caused controversy in the past when they accidentally attached highly explicit images or links to pornographic websites. These mistakes can happen due to minor carelessness, but can attract significant negative publicity which isn't good.

You don't want to fall victim to such craziness. So, it's best to carefully check and recheck the post before you schedule it for later.

When you manage content for multiple social platforms or working as a social media marketer for multiple businesses, there is a higher risk of making mistakes. For instance, you may want to schedule a post via software for Twitter, but accidentally do so for another website. While this mistake may not appear insignificant, it can promote a negative image of your business.

Lastly, it's a good idea to create social media posts for prominent occasions, events, and festivals, but make sure you schedule it for the right time and date. What if you create an Instagram post for Halloween, but due to the scheduling mistake, it gets posted a day or two after the holiday? You may become the laughing stock for the audience.

If This, Then That? Social Media Automation

If-then concept is a basic principle of computer programming where you specify the system to check for the defined condition and execute the specific block of code only if it meets the condition. IFTTT platform was developed with the intention to provide similar functionality to social media marketers.

This platform allows marketers to create applets for automated content. You can create posts for suitable social websites and specify the trigger point. When the specified action is triggered, the post applet will be published.

However, using the IFTTT model may not be your best bet when it comes to comments. Some businesses use bots to post automated comments. These comments don't only seem fake, but they also portray a negative image of the company.

Alternatively, it can be used to improve customer service. For instance, you can use this model with a messaging app to facilitate customers. You can specify answers to most common queries that are frequently asked.

For example, when a customer enquires you about your working hours or the prices of your products, they can receive an automated answer to their query. This practice saves time and provides answers to customers without unnecessary delays.

Although automation can make your job easier to some extent, it never works for marketers to create a post and then forget about it. As a result, it may get published at an inappropriate time and seem irrelevant. You should go through the scheduled content from time to time and tweak posts if needed.

Analyze That

If this then that is a valuable automation tool. Not only does it enable you to automate social media posts for business promotion purposes, but you can also use it for personal reasons. For instance, you can use this tool to wish colleagues on their birthdays or work anniversaries.

However, this functionality should be used carefully. This tool posts the same content every time an event takes place. In certain cases, this may get out of hand.

When an existing or potential customer messages a brand, they often receive an automated message where they are addressed with their first name. This may cause an embarrassing situation for businesses in some cases. A few years ago, a brand used this function on Twitter where they were addressed with their user name. But the user had previously changed their profile name with a profane and the tweet made the brand look bad to other users.

Such events aren't common and don't happen too often. But they can lead to an embarrassing situation for your business and may deter the customer base. So, before you opt for the IFTTT model, you should evaluate your decision and come up with suitable content that is less likely to lead to controversy.

Reading

<https://www.cincopa.com/blog/the-ultimate-guide-to-scheduling-video-posts-on-social-media/>

<https://blog.oneupapp.io/social-media-scheduling-tools/>

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3.8: We're Engaged! Aren't We?

When you create business profiles on social media, you may aim to increase the number of followers through content marketing. Increasing your follower base is certainly important for your brand, but you should also focus on increasing engagement for long-term benefits.

Social media engagement refers to likes, comments, and shares on posts by other social media users. Not all of your followers are active and many of them may forget about you after liking your page on Facebook or following you on Instagram. In this sense, engagement is far more impactful since it indicates that your followers not only see your posts, but also interact with you one way or another.

The phrase *out of sight, out of mind* is certainly true and is applicable in the scenario of business marketing. With the internet making it easier to reach a global audience and promote and sell products without hassles, more and more businesses are entering the market and leading to increased competition. If your content reaches them and captures their attention, they would stay with you provided that your products and customer service meet their needs. But it won't take long for them to switch to your competitor brands if you ghost them and your content stops reaching their social media timeline.

If they often interact with your brand, the social media algorithm would show them your content on priority and ensure that they remember you. Therefore, not only should you create engaging content, but also monitor the engagement rate.

There are many different tools available that can help you keep track of customer engagement on social media including Twitter Counter, Buzzlogix, Zoho Social, and Agorapulse that can help you monitor the engagement rate as well as brand reputation across social platforms.

What If They Don't Talk Back?

Customer engagement is a key concern for brands. The more customers interact with social media posts, the more impact your business makes in the market. This is a good sign because engagement is the driving force of ROI and makes the business profitable down the road.

However, even though business marketers try their best to attract the target audience and encourage them to like or comment on their posts, they are not always able to achieve this goal. This situation is troublesome and can make you wonder why your entire efforts are going in vain.

To get the answer, you should first analyze your current social media strategy. It's possible that your content is of low-quality or doesn't interest your audience. It's also a possibility that your choice of social website isn't right. With this detailed analysis, you may find out potential issues with your strategy and revise it to address those issues.

However, it should also be noted that defective strategy isn't always the cause of low engagement. You may need to develop more interesting content to capture the attention. It may be a good idea to hold live Q&A sessions.

Customers are no longer interested in listening to faceless brands. They rather find the human side of brands more attractive and engage with them on social media. By introducing them to your team and interacting with them via live sessions, you can win their trust and increase engagement.

Customer-generated content can also help you in this regard. You shouldn't only create and share your own content, but also retweet, or like, or share relevant posts by followers. For instance, if you find an interesting post of your followers discussing the niche or topic related to your business, you should consider sharing it with your follower base.

Influencer marketing can also be a good option. You can get in touch with social media influencers who have built a community of followers and ask them to promote your brand. When they endorse your business, their followers will visit your social profile and may engage with the content if they find it interesting.

Should I Still Use Email?

Some people claim that email is a feature of the past and has lost its importance over time. However, digital marketers are well-aware this statement is far from the truth. Despite the popularity of other online marketing methods, email promotions are still extremely effective.

Most consumers check their emails on a daily basis which is why there is no better way for marketers to share information about their market offerings and latest product launches. You can send newsletters to customers and leads and invite them to read the

latest blog posts, visit your social media, and learn about what's new.

Email is relevant in the era of social media because it is a helpful tool for increasing website traffic and generating or capturing qualified leads. You can also curate content and send customized information to customer groups as per their interests. This targeted information can help in building strong relationships and entice customers to interact with you.

Once they are directed to your website to get more information, there is a good chance they will go through the list of products you sell and purchase them soon.

What If They're Upset

Businesses that value their customers work extra hard to provide them an unprecedented and memorable experience. However, they may not be able to achieve this goal every time. Despite your best efforts, some customers may still be unhappy and dissatisfied.

Unhappy customers often post negative reviews about brands on social media pages or Facebook groups. If you notice such a review, you should get ready to resolve the situation instead of losing your cool.

You should calmly listen to customers and apologize for the mistake. If it was a genuine problem, then you should empathize and assure them that the management would look into the matter and resolve the problem at the earliest. You can also send them a gift or discount voucher to make up for their bad experience.

Some customers may accept your apology and let it go, but some customers get too angry and they don't listen to social media managers. They may continue posting negative reviews about your business and hurt your brand reputation.

In this scenario, the best strategy is to use tracking tools like Mention that keep you updated about discussions and reviews about your business. With this real-time information, you can tackle the situation and spread positive messages about your brand to prevent them from further hurting your business.

Don't Feed the Trolls

Some angry customers post negative reviews because they genuinely faced a bad experience with your company. But remember that some social media users deliberately post provocative content against other users and businesses out of habit.

They poke fun at others and humiliate them with derogatory content. Interacting with such trolls and responding to their comments can further ignite the situation. So, you need to tactfully handle the situation.

First of all, write terms and policies for your community where followers are expected to be respectful of others and refrain from using offensive language. You can politely ask trolls to be mindful in the light of community policies. You can respond to fake posts regarding your business with facts or ignore them. You can also come up with witty responses to diffuse the situation.

However, social media trolls don't go away easily and they may keep trying to instigate you. Don't get into the trap and stay calm and respectful to protect your brand image.

Do the Hokey Pokey: Turn Complaints into Gold

Brands that often receive negative comments and reviews tend to lose customers and damage the reputation. But customer complaints and negative comments aren't as bad as they are perceived.

These posts give you a chance to identify and recognize your mistakes. Your business processes or products may be harmful in some manner or fail to meet the needs of customers. Instead of treating these comments as trash and ignoring them, you should treat them as feedback and make the most of this constructive feedback to enhance service quality.

If a customer points out that the behavior of the staff wasn't good, you should pay attention to them. Offering excuses won't do good as it gives the impression that you don't consider customer complaints important. You can rather arrange training sessions for team members to help them boost their skillset and improve service quality.

You should encourage customers and social media followers to offer suggestions for further improving your business processes. Also, once you implement a customer suggestion, you should post it on social media and appreciate customer feedback.

Do You Even Care?

Customer service is a challenging job. You need to listen to customer complaints and suggestions, and bear their anger while taking the blame for intentional or unintentional mistakes.

No matter what type of business you manage, effective customer service is the key to success. You should always prioritize customers and work hard to add value to them. Similarly, listening to and addressing customer issues is equally important for a business.

Customers are now aware of their rights and they don't want to do anything with businesses that ignore them. To become an effective business leader or social media marketer, you ought to care about your customers. You don't want to receive negative reviews due to the negligence of your team. You should develop a culture within the organization where staff members consider it their first and foremost responsibility to take care of customers and leave no stone unturned in achieving customer satisfaction.

This approach strengthens relationships with customers and creates a lasting bond.

Reading

<https://www.omnिकick.com/customer-engagement-strategies/>

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3.9: Social Media Jobs. Why Understanding Basic Marketing Principles Will Put You Ahead of the Rest

It's a prevalent myth that social media management is all about mastering different social media websites. The better you are with using the latest technology and creating and posting content across social accounts, the more successful you will be along the journey.

However, social media management is more about marketing than using social accounts. Therefore, you ought to grasp basic marketing principles. If you understand basic marketing concepts, you can stand out and do well as compared to other candidates.

The evolution of technology has offered a variety of platforms to marketers, but marketing principles stay almost the same. If you know marketing, you can apply these principles to promote a brand online and generate results.

The Intern Always Gets Blamed

At the beginning of your professional journey, you may need to work as an intern to get experience, increase knowledge, and learn useful skills alongside experienced professionals.

The internship is a rewarding yet challenging job. You get the opportunity to gain plenty of useful information, but the tasks can be never-ending. Moreover, if anything goes wrong, there is a good chance you will be blamed for the mistake as the junior-most staff member in the organization.

It's a part of the learning journey. You need to be headstrong and accept feedback without getting angry. This knowledge will help you when you start working as a regular social media management employee and can use this learning to your advantage.

How Boring is Your Resume?

When you apply for a job, the resume is your first introduction to potential employers. They decide whether or not it's a good idea to interview you for the job based on this professional document. If it's too boring, lacks information, and doesn't highlight the information they are looking for, you can already say goodbye to that internship opportunity you have been dreaming of.

Recruiters evaluate your skills, personality, strengths, and qualifications with the help of your resume. So, you can't ignore the importance of this document. If you have got rejected by recruiters or afraid that recruiters may not consider your application, then it's a good idea to update and redesign your resume.

It's best to invest in an attractive resume design that highlights your skills, qualifications, experience, and personal strengths. At the beginning of the career, you may benefit from a chronological order resume or design a custom theme that fits the specifications of organizations where you want to apply for a social media marketing vacancy.

Since recruiters get a huge number of candidate resumes, you can get more visibility and an edge over other candidates with the help of an attractive document format. Before finalizing it, make sure you proofread the document for potential errors and spice it up with attractive designs to increase your chance of getting hired.

Is LinkedIn Still a Thing?

Launched in 2003 as a social network for professionals, LinkedIn has been going strong since its inception. It is one of the best websites to set up your professional profile and interact with professional experts from different fields.

LinkedIn facilitates you to share thoughts and knowledge with other users on the platform who might be interested in the insights you share. You can also have one-on-one chats with people via its secure private message service.

Since LinkedIn is getting old, it is rumored that this platform is losing its charm. However, it's an evergreen platform that is extremely useful in this era of technology.

Many recruiters prefer to invite and hire candidates via LinkedIn. It's because they can evaluate the person to some extent before the interview with the help of their profile and the content they share. In fact, many recruiters conduct short interviews through LinkedIn to save time and make the recruitment process much simpler.

So, it's recommended for business professionals, especially marketers to create LinkedIn profiles. If you stay active and regularly post relevant and informative content, you can build relationships and get job offers with ease.

Going Solo

Working as a social media marketer with an expert team of professionals can offer you learning opportunities. You can get useful tips those team members learned through years of experience. They can also guide you about enhancing your skills and the right path for progressing in the industry.

However, taking up a full-time job isn't for everyone. You may have dreams of making your name as an established social media marketer and this dream can come true only by working solo and launching your entrepreneurial career.

You may want to become a freelancer and gradually set up your social media marketing agency once you build a network of business connections and clients.

Before starting your agency, you ought to develop a business plan that covers necessary information about the business such as potential customers, vendors, business strategy, financial resources to execute plans, and your team that can work hard for the future of the organization. You may want to invest in a professional website to build authenticity and credibility.

Building Your Portfolio

Whether you plan to take up a job as a social media marketer or aim to launch your social media agency, you need a portfolio. A portfolio is a set of previous work that demonstrates your skills.

When you send your resume to a potential employer, they would ask for your portfolio to determine how good you are at what you do. Similarly, this portfolio will prove helpful when you reach clients and offer your social media management services for their business or professional needs.

As a beginner at social media marketing, you may struggle to get your first job or assignment. You can create social media profiles for your freelancing journey. By managing these accounts the right way, you can show clients and recruiters that you are good at the job.

Furthermore, you can also present detailed insights into the performance of social media campaigns you may carry out to promote your personal brand.

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3.10: YOLO

Social media marketing is the need of the hour. Not only does it help individuals stay connected, it also adds value to businesses with low cost and effective marketing methods.

Traditional marketing is still relevant, but digital marketing in general and social media marketing, in particular, is extremely helpful for entrepreneurs. It can be an invaluable asset for lead generation, raising brand awareness, engaging existing customers, and acquiring new customers at relatively lower rates.

However, social websites such as Facebook, LinkedIn, Twitter, and other platforms can be tricky. Not every marketer is able to get the desired results via social media marketing despite their familiarity with social media websites. This is because they ignore the basic principles of marketing, especially the marketing mix or 4 P's principle.

Social marketing works on the basis of these fundamental marketing principles and you need to rethink these concepts in the context of digital media to achieve your marketing goals.

The key to surviving in the digital world is to understand the needs and wants of your customers. When you know which platforms are most commonly used by your target audience, then you can stay active on those websites to increase your reach.

It's also essential to monitor the activities of your competitors. This practice helps you learn about the latest industry trends, identify your mistakes, and learn from those that have working in the marketing industry for quite a long time. You can update your social marketing strategy accordingly for better results.

Despite these tactics, your business may suffer if you blindly follow in the footsteps of the competition. You should rather develop an effective strategy that suits your particular needs.

For this purpose, you should first define your goals for social marketing campaigns and specify your target audience. The next step is to identify where these customers are mostly present and then create social media accounts on those websites. It's important to remember that you cannot and should not try to run marketing campaigns on every social media website or this approach will only backfire.

The next step is to develop a content strategy for these websites. You should know what kind of content is popular on each website so you can post it when most of your target audience is online. You don't need to create fresh content for every website and can rather repurpose and reuse it to avoid wasting time.

Moreover, there are many tools or software available that can assist you in creating unique content and repurposing the existing information. You can use these tools to maintain a content calendar and schedule social media posts so they reach your target customers at the right time.

Social marketing efforts produce results when you stay up-to-date with performance. Social media built-in tools as well as external performance measurement software can give you detailed information about the performance of marketing campaigns. You can find out which activities are performing as per expectations and which tactics need to be revised. With the help of this information, you can update and revise the social media strategy for improved performance.

This book is the first step in the right direction and provides you with guidelines for prospering as a social media marketer. However, you can learn best by implementing these principles and activities on your own. Hands-on experience further clarifies concepts, gives you a better understanding of digital and social media marketing, and helps you get down to the nitty-gritty of modern marketing strategies.

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3.12: Facebook a Meta

Founded in 2004, Facebook's mission is to give people the power to share and make the world more open and connected. People use Facebook to stay connected with friends and family, to discover what's going on in the world, and to share and express what matters to them.^[1]

 Statistic: Share of Facebook users in the United States as of March 2023, by age group | Statista

1. <https://investor.fb.com/investor-new...s/default.aspx> ↗
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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

4: Course Project

4.1: Course Project - Create a Social Media Strategy

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4.1: Course Project - Create a Social Media Strategy

Course Project: Social Media Strategy

Throughout this semester, you'll develop a social media marketing strategy for a specific company or department within the university. You'll pick a client/company (real or fictional), focusing on an organization with a decision-maker for whom you'll design the marketing strategy. No need for actual access to the organization – 'client' simply means you can't choose an industry for this project.

Due Dates:

Steps 1-2: February 23

Steps 3-4: March 9

Steps 5-7: April 6

Steps 8-10: May 4

We'll also have assignments to create content for posting along the way. Your final submission will include a written proposal of all 10 steps and a short video (20 minutes max) to describe your strategy to the client. Due May 4 (In-person classes will present in class).

Step 1. Business Scope

Gather intel on the client's mission, product/service, market, and competitors. If possible, define their Why, How, and What; if not, suggest creating one.

Step 2. Aiming High

Outline the client's business and social media goals – engagement, growth, or ROI.

Step 3. Eye on the Customer

Identify target audiences using client criteria or platform data, and create customer personas with demographics and psychographics.

Step 4. Know the Competition

Examine competitors' social media performance and compare it to the client's. Identify standout tactics for both.

Step 5. Social Media Checkup

Assess what's working or not, audience engagement, target audience network usage, and comparison to the competition.

Step 6. Tone It Up

Decide on a communication style for your strategy based on audience, personas, and platform suggestions. Include a hashtag strategy.

Step 7. Content Countdown

Pick the networks to use based on target audience and persona data. Create a content calendar for March, April, and May.

Step 8. Content Crafting

Develop content, captions, posting dates/times, including photos, videos, links, reposts, and captions.

Step 9. Platform Play

Choose platforms and software for scheduling, posting, and engaging with content (Meta Business Manager/ Creator Studio, Tailwind, Iconosquare, Buffer, Hootsuite, Creator Studio, IFTTT, etc.).

Step 10. Measure and Report

Submit your overall strategy, content plan, and any analytics available from posted content.

Turn in your written strategy and record a video describing your plan and any available analytics (for in-person class, present to the class).

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